16 DEVOTIONALS ON FIRST TIMOTHY

Faithful in God's Household

Dr. Johannes (Hannes) A. Nortjé

How to use this booklet

1. Set aside about 15 to 20 minutes for each day, ideally somewhere quiet.
2. Read the Scripture passage first, slowly – aloud, if you can. It stands at the start of each devotional.
3. “Digging Deeper” takes you into the context and the language of the original text. “Living It Out” asks what it means for you.
4. Take your time with the questions. You may want to write your answers down.
5. Close with the prayer – and with your own words.

Faithful in God's Household
16 devotionals on First Timothy

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Read online: https://hannesnortje.github.io/devotionals/1tim/en/

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DAY 1

Guarding the Purity of the Gospel

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 1:1–11

[1] Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the command of God our Saviour
and of Christ Jesus our hope, [2] to Timothy, my true child in the faith:
grace, mercy and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord.

[3] As I urged you when I was going on to Macedonia, stay on in Ephesus,
so that you may instruct certain people not to teach a different doctrine
[4] and not to occupy themselves with myths and endless genealogies,
which produce speculations rather than God's ordering of things,
which is by faith – [5] but the goal of our instruction is love from a pure
heart, from a good conscience and from a sincere faith. [6] Some have
strayed from these and have turned aside to empty talk. [7] They want to
be teachers of the law, without understanding either what they are saying or the things about which they make such confident claims. [8] Now
we know that the law is good, if one uses it lawfully, [9] knowing this: the
law is not laid down for the righteous, but for the lawless and rebellious,
for the ungodly and sinners, for the unholy and profane, for those who
kill their fathers or their mothers, for murderers, [10] for the sexually immoral, for men who have sex with men, for slave traders, for liars, for
perjurers, and for whatever else is contrary to sound teaching, [11] in
keeping with the gospel of the glory of the blessed God, which was entrusted to me.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Today we begin a sixteen-day journey through Paul's first letter to Timothy. It is a letter full of fatherly care and apostolic urgency, written to a young leader standing in the middle of a difficult church. Day by day

we will discover what God's household looks like when it is ordered by his Word: sound teaching, prayer, faithful leaders, care for the vulnerable and a life of godliness.

Paul probably wrote this letter between AD 62 and 64, after his release from his first Roman imprisonment. He had left his young spiritual son and co-worker Timothy behind in Ephesus – a cosmopolitan port city, famous for the vast temple of Artemis, for magic, commercial wealth and a mix of religious ideologies. Yet the danger to the church was not only persecution from outside, but decay from within: leaders who had begun to mix the gospel with myths, speculative genealogies and a distorted legalism.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

In the Greek text Paul goes straight to the heart of the matter with carefully chosen words:

- **"Teach a different doctrine" (*heterodidaskalein* – ἑτεροδιδασκαλεῖν, v. 3):** Timothy is to instruct certain people *"not to teach a different doctrine"*. The compound word literally means to spread teaching of a strange, deviating kind. Any teaching that shifts or replaces the complete saving work of Jesus Christ with human speculation is, for Paul, a deadly deviation.
- **"The goal of our instruction" (*telos tēs parangelias* – τέλος τῆς παραγγελίας, v. 5):** Paul uses the word *telos*: the final destination, the completed outcome. The goal of all sound biblical teaching is not intellectual superiority or winning arguments, but **love** (*agapē*) – divine, self-giving love. This love has a threefold source: *"a pure heart"* (*kardia kathara*), *"a good conscience"* (*syneidēsis agathē*) and *"a sincere faith"* (*pistis anypokritos* – literally an unhypocritical faith, faith without a mask or play-acting).

- **"Empty talk" (*mataiologia* – ματαιολογία, v. 6):** Those who stray from this clear line fall into *"empty talk"* – fruitless chatter that carries no eternal weight.
- **"Sound teaching" (*hygiainousē didaskalia* – ὑγιαινούσῃ διδασκαλίᾳ, v. 10):** The phrase comes from the verb *hygiainō* (from which we get the word "hygiene"). It describes teaching that gives life, keeps us spiritually healthy and strengthens our defences – in sharp contrast to the toxic effects of false teaching.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Sound teaching is known by its fruit in life and relationships.** True biblical truth always leads to greater love for God and people, joined to a clear conscience. When theological debates breed bitterness, pride and division, they have lost their *telos*.
2. **The law is a diagnostic tool, not a cure.** Paul explains that the law is good *"if one uses it lawfully"* (v. 8). It was given to expose the rebellion, ungodliness and moral corruption of fallen humanity – to lay the wound open so that the sinner realises he needs the Physician. It cannot wash the conscience clean; only Christ can do that.
3. **The gospel is about God's glory.** In verse 11 Paul anchors his message in *"the gospel of the glory of the blessed God"*. The good news is not a man-made philosophy but a precious treasure entrusted by God, which must be kept unadulterated.

Living It Out

We live in a culture flooded with information, opinions and theological controversy. On social media and even inside churches it is easy to get caught up in today's "myths and endless genealogies" – new spiritual fads, sensational end-times speculation, or legalistic lists of what a "real" believer must do according to people.

Paul reminds us that spiritual maturity is not measured by how many debates you can win or how much specialist knowledge you have. The real test of your faith is this: **Does love flow from your heart? Is your conscience clear before God? Is your faith genuine and free of hypocrisy?**

When you study Scripture, it should not puff you up with pride, but humble you before God's holiness and fill you with mercy towards others.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Where does my energy go?** Do I spend more time and energy on speculative, polarising issues than on the simple, powerful core of the gospel and discipleship?
- **Is my faith sincere?** If I look honestly at my daily life, do I live with a faith that wears no mask – or do I try to make a pious impression while my inner life is empty?
- **Mirror or hammer?** Do I use God's truth as a mirror to examine myself and run to grace – or as a hammer to condemn others?

Prayer

> *Lord God, our Saviour and our eternal hope, I bow before you in reverence for your Word.*
>
> *Forgive me where I have so often let my attention be stolen by empty talk, speculation and things that do not build your kingdom. Guard my mind and my heart from every teaching that turns my gaze away from Jesus Christ and his complete work of salvation.*
>
> *Today I ask you for a pure heart that seeks your face alone. Wash my conscience clean through the precious blood of your Son, so that I may stand before you with confidence. Strip away from me all falseness, play-acting and religious show, and give me a sincere faith. Let the fruit of my life and my words always be true, godly love that honours your name.*

> *In the name of Jesus Christ, our Lord and Teacher. Amen.*

DAY 2

Grace for the Worst of Sinners

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 1:12–17

12 I give thanks to him who has strengthened me, Christ Jesus our Lord,
because he judged me faithful and appointed me to his service, 13 though
I was formerly a blasphemer, a persecutor and a violent man. But I was
shown mercy, because I acted in ignorance and unbelief. 14 And the
grace of our Lord overflowed, together with the faith and love that are
in Christ Jesus. 15 This is a trustworthy saying and deserves full accep-
tance: Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners – and of them I
am the first. 16 But for this very reason I was shown mercy: so that in
me, as the first, Christ Jesus might display his complete patience, as an
example for those who were going to believe in him for eternal life.

17 Now to the King of the ages,
the imperishable, invisible, only God,
be honour and glory for ever and ever. Amen.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday Paul warned against false teachers who misuse the law in a legalistic, speculative way. Now he suddenly turns to his own life story. This is not self-absorbed nostalgia; it is a masterful theological contrast. While the false teachers were proud of their outward knowledge and man-made rules, Paul shows that the true gospel is a power that can transform the most hardened rebel – without any human merit at all.

Paul looks back without embarrassment on his past as Saul of Tarsus (Acts 8–9). He does not gloss over his sins, but uses their shocking reality as the dark background against which God's mercy shines all the brighter.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek wording reveals how deep Paul's wonder runs:

- **"A violent man" (*hybristēs* – ὑβριστής, v. 13):** Paul calls himself not only *"a blasphemer"* (*blasphēmos*) and *"a persecutor"* (*diōktēs*), but also *"a violent man"* (*hybristēs*). The word describes someone driven by arrogant, violent contempt – a bully who deliberately tramples on other people's dignity and lives. Saul dragged believers from their homes, tried to force them to blaspheme, and approved of their deaths.
- **"Overflowed" (*hyperepleonasen* – ὑπερεπλεόνασεν, v. 14):** Paul writes: *"And the grace of our Lord overflowed."* In Greek this is a compound word with the prefix *hyper-* (over and above, beyond measure). Grace did not just barely cover Paul's guilt; like a tidal wave it swept over his sinful past and swallowed it whole. Where sin was great, grace overflowed infinitely more.
- **"This is a trustworthy saying" (*pistos ho logos* – πιστὸς ὁ λόγος, v. 15):** This is the first of five such "trustworthy sayings" in the Pastoral Letters (1 and 2 Timothy and Titus). It points to a well-known early Christian confession that served the church like an anchor: *"Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners."*
- **"The first" (*prōtos* – πρῶτος, vv. 15–16):** Paul calls himself the *"first"* of sinners: *"of them I am the first"*. This does not simply mean first in time, but foremost in rank, seriousness and extent. Our translation deliberately keeps the word "first" so that the link to verse 16 stays visible: it was "in me as the first" that Christ chose to display his patience. Notice the tense: he does not say "of whom I *was* the first", but *"I am the first"*. The closer a believer lives to the light of God's holiness, the more sharply he sees his own corruption and his need of grace.
- **"An example" (*hypotypōsis* – ὑποτύπωσις, v. 16):** Paul says he was saved to be *"an example"*. A *hypotypōsis* was a draft sketch, a model, a prototype. Paul is God's showpiece of patience (*makrothymia*). If God could

save and transform Saul the persecutor, there is no sinner on earth beyond the reach of his saving hand.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Grace chooses the most unlikely candidates.** God is not looking for people who think they are righteous; Christ came for sinners. Ministry is not a reward for good behaviour but a gift of grace.
2. **Ignorance does not excuse sin, but it opens the door to mercy.** Paul admits that he *"acted in ignorance and unbelief"* (v. 13). His ignorance did not make him innocent, but it shows that his rebellion was not a final, deliberate rejection of known divine light – and so God's mercy could reach him.
3. **God uses our story as a beacon of hope.** Your salvation is not only about you; it is a public display of God's patience for others who are yet to believe.
4. **True theology always ends in doxology.** In verse 17 Paul bursts spontaneously into worship: *"Now to the King of the ages, the imperishable, invisible, only God, be honour and glory for ever and ever."* When you understand how great your salvation is, you cannot stay silent.

Living It Out

Many believers walk around every day with a heavy load of secret guilt and shame. They look at their past – mistakes they have made, words they have spoken, people they have hurt – and think: *"Maybe God can forgive me, but he can never really use me."*

Paul's testimony blows this lie away completely. If God could use the man who looked after the coats of those who stoned Stephen, he can restore and use you too. Your past does not disqualify you from God's future; it becomes the very background against which his grace shines brightest.

At the same time, this passage disarms all spiritual pride. When we look at the world around us – at people caught in gross sin or in hostility towards the church – we must not respond with contempt, but with the knowledge: "*I was there myself. Of sinners I am the first, saved only by undeserved grace.*"

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **What am I holding back?** Are there sins or failures in my past that I refuse to entrust to God's forgiveness – and am I letting shame paralyse my service?
- **How do I see others?** When I look at people living in rebellion against God, do I look at them with self-righteous condemnation – or with the mercy of someone who knows how great a debt Christ has cancelled for me?
- **Where is my praise?** When did reflecting on God's grace last lead me spontaneously into worship and praise, as it did Paul in verse 17?

Prayer

Lord God, King of the ages, imperishable, invisible and only God,

this morning I bow before you with a heart overflowing with gratitude. With Paul I must confess that I had no claim on your favour. My own righteousness is like a stained garment, and in myself I deserve nothing but your judgement. And yet your grace has overflowed in my life through Christ Jesus.

Thank you that Jesus came into this broken world to save sinners. Thank you that you did not leave me where my sin had put me, but drew me with cords of love and mercy. Forgive me where I become proud towards others, as if my salvation were my own achievement.

Take my life today, Lord. Let my mistakes, my scars and my redemption be a living example of your unsurpassed patience, so that others may find hope in your Son. To you alone belong honour, praise and glory for ever and ever.

In the precious name of Jesus Christ, our Lord. Amen.

DAY 3

Wage the Good Warfare with a Good Conscience

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 1:18–20

18 This instruction I entrust to you, Timothy, my child, in keeping with
the prophecies once made about you, so that by them you may wage the
good warfare, 19 holding on to faith and a good conscience. Some have
pushed this conscience aside and have made shipwreck of their faith.
20 Among them are Hymenaeus and Alexander, whom I have handed
over to Satan, so that they may be taught not to blaspheme.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday Paul celebrated his own radical conversion and God's overflowing mercy. Now he turns his gaze directly back to Timothy. The apostolic tone softens into fatherly closeness: "*Timothy, my child*". Yet the message that follows is anything but soft; it is a call to courage on a spiritual battlefield.

Timothy faced a daunting task. He was relatively young, probably cautious or reserved by nature, and in Ephesus he had to stand up to established, eloquent false teachers who had influence in the church. Paul ties him to his spiritual anchors: "*the prophecies once made about you*" – probably at his commissioning and the laying on of hands for ministry (see 1 Timothy 4:14). These confirmations were not mere memories; they were spiritual armour for hard times.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Here the Greek text exposes a vital link between heart and mind:

- **"This instruction" (*parangelia* – παραγγελία, v. 18):** Paul again uses the word for an official "*instruction*", a command coming from the commander-in-chief (see vv. 3 and 5). Timothy does not act on his own authority; he carries out the orders of King Jesus.
- **"Wage the good warfare" (*strateuē tēn kalēn strateian* – στρατεύῃ τὴν καλὴν στρατείαν, v. 18):** Timothy is to *"wage the good warfare"*. The Greek word *strateia* means a long military campaign, not just a single short skirmish. This campaign is *kalos* – noble, beautiful, just and morally pure. The Christian life is a deliberate campaign against sin, temptation and falsehood. (At the end of the letter, in 6:12, Paul uses a different picture from the athletic arena: *"Fight the good fight of the faith."*)
- **"A good conscience" (*agathē syneidēsis* – ἀγαθὴ συνείδησις, v. 19):** Paul joins two inseparable realities: *pistis* (faith, the truth of the teaching) and *agathē syneidēsis* (a good, clean conscience). The conscience is God's inner moral monitor. A good conscience means that your actions match the light God has given you.
- **"Pushed aside" (*apōsamenoi* – ἀπωσάμενοι, v. 19):** Paul warns: *"Some have pushed this conscience aside."* The verb describes a violent, deliberate rejection – shoving something away from you with contempt. People rarely lose their faith because of purely intellectual questions; the process almost always begins when they choose to silence their conscience so that they can go on in sin.
- **"Made shipwreck" (*enauagēsan* – ἐναυάγησαν, v. 19):** If you throw the compass of conscience overboard, the inevitable result follows: you *"make shipwreck"* of your faith. Ephesus was a busy port; every inhabitant knew what a wooden ship looked like after the waves had smashed it on the rocks.
- **"Handed over to Satan" (*paredōka tō Satana* – παρέδωκα τῷ Σατανᾷ, v. 20):** Paul names two people – *"Hymenaeus and Alexander"* (probably leaders who denied the resurrection or twisted the teaching; see 2

Timothy 2:17). He says he has *"handed [them] over to Satan"*. This refers to formal church discipline (excommunication). They were removed from the protective fellowship of the local church and put back into the world, where Satan exercises his power (see 1 Corinthians 5:5). But the aim was restoration, not destruction: *hina paideuthōsi – "so that they may be taught not to blaspheme"*. Church discipline aims to lead the offender to repentance, healing and restoration.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Confession and lifestyle cannot be separated.** You cannot hold on to sound teaching while living in deliberate disobedience. A compromise in your ethics inevitably leads to error in your theology, to justify your sin.
2. **The conscience is an essential navigation instrument.** Ignoring your conscience again and again is like smashing the warning lights on the dashboard of your soul.
3. **Spiritual warfare needs reminders of God's calling.** When persecution or discouragement strikes, the believer must fall back on God's promises and the certainty of his calling.
4. **God's discipline serves restoration.** Even the church's most drastic judgement aims to bring sinners to stop blaspheming and humble themselves before God.

Living It Out

Nobody becomes a spiritual wreck overnight. Shipwreck rarely happens because a ship suddenly breaks in two on a calm sea. It happens when a captain allows small deviations from course, ignores the warning signs of the lighthouse, or deliberately sails too close to dangerous reefs.

When you ignore the voice of the Holy Spirit in your conscience – over a dishonest business deal, bitterness you nurse, compromises with pornography or sexual impurity, or gossip – the process of hardening begins.

Every time you "push your conscience aside", the inner voice grows quieter and your heart harder. In the end people adjust their convictions to fit their lifestyle and start twisting Scripture to excuse their disobedience.

As soldiers of Christ we are to wage the good warfare. That means watching over the small decisions of the heart we make every day. A clean conscience before God and people is the greatest source of confidence and spiritual strength a believer can have.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Where is the red light flashing?** Is there an area of my life right now where my conscience is flashing a warning, but I keep pushing it aside or justifying it?
- **Where do I anchor my soul?** When I feel spiritually discouraged or exhausted in the battle, what do I anchor my soul to – my own emotions, or God's eternal promises and my calling?
- **Does my inside match my outside?** Do I live so transparently that my private life fully matches the teaching I confess with my mouth?

Prayer

> *Heavenly Father, Lord of hosts and Keeper of my soul,*
>
> *you have called me to be a good soldier of Jesus Christ – not to seek my own comfort, but to wage faithfully the noble campaign for the truth of your gospel. I confess that the battle is sometimes exhausting and that doubt and temptation strike hard at my mind.*
>
> *Lord, today I ask you for the gift of a good, finely tuned conscience, and that you would keep it. Keep me from pushing your gentle warnings aside. Forgive me where I have compromised with things that grieve your Spirit. Wash my conscience clean through the precious blood of Christ, and give me grace to confess quickly and turn straight back to you.*

Do not let my faith be shipwrecked on the rocks of pride, worldliness or disobedience. Make me steadfast in the truth, faithful to my calling and persevering until the day I stand before your face.

In the mighty and victorious name of Jesus Christ. Amen.

DAY 4

Prayer for All and the One Mediator

SCRIPTURE
1 Timothy 2:1–7

[1] First of all, then, I urge that petitions, prayers, intercessions and thanksgivings be made for all people, [2] for kings and all who are in high positions, so that we may lead a peaceful and quiet life in all godliness and dignity. [3] This is good and pleasing before God our Saviour, [4] who wants all people to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth.

[5] For there is one God,
and there is one mediator between God and humankind,
the man Christ Jesus,
[6] who gave himself as a ransom for all –
the testimony at the proper time.

[7] For this I was appointed a herald and an apostle – I am telling the truth, I am not lying – a teacher of the nations in faith and truth.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In chapter 1 Paul defended the purity of the gospel and shared his own testimony of grace. In chapter 2 he turns to public life and the ordered gathering of the local church. He begins with the weighty words "*First of all*" (*prōton pantōn*). This does not just mean the first item on a list, but priority in rank and importance. Before the church makes rules or appoints leaders, it must kneel. Prayer is the foundation on which everything else the church does rests.

The historical background makes Paul's instruction breathtakingly radical. When Paul wrote these words, the notorious emperor Nero sat on the throne in Rome. The Roman authorities were pagan, often corrupt and

hostile to the young Christian faith. Yet the apostle does not call for revolt, civil disobedience or bitter curses. He urges persistent, all-embracing prayer *"for kings and all who are in high positions"*.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Here the Greek text unfolds a rich picture of the praying life and of salvation:

- **Four dimensions of prayer (v. 1):**
  - *"Petitions"* (*deēseis* – δεήσεις): prayers that spring from an urgent awareness of our own weakness, lack and dependence on God.
  - *"Prayers"* (*proseuchas* – προσευχάς): the general, sacred term used only for worship and reverent approach to the true God.
  - *"Intercessions"* (*enteuxeis* – ἐντεύξεις): a term from the royal court. It means coming boldly and personally before a ruler on someone else's behalf to ask for his intervention.
  - *"Thanksgivings"* (*eucharistias* – εὐχαριστίας): the deliberate acknowledgement of God's goodness – even with regard to people who oppress us or with whom we disagree.
- **"A peaceful and quiet life" (*ēremon kai hēsychion bion* – *ἤρεμον καὶ ἡσύχιον βίον*, v. 2):** The aim of praying for rulers is that believers *"may lead a peaceful and quiet life"*. *Ēremos* (peaceful) refers to outward calm, free from persecution and civil war; *hēsychios* (quiet) to peace within, free from anxiety and unrest. (The same word *hēsychia* meets us again tomorrow in vv. 11–12.) This peace is not meant for selfish comfort, but so that the gospel can be proclaimed without hindrance – *"in all godliness* (*eusebeia*) *and dignity* (*semnotēs*)".
- **"Who wants all people to be saved" (*pantas anthrōpous thelei sōthēnai* – *πάντας ἀνθρώπους θέλει σωθῆναι*, v. 4):** Here Paul confronts the pagan and Jewish exclusivism of his day. Salvation is not limited to a spir-

itual elite, a single nation or a privileged social class. From beggars to tyrannical kings – God's merciful invitation reaches every group of humankind.

- **"Mediator" (*mesitēs* – μεσίτης, v. 5):** A mediator stands between two estranged parties to bring about reconciliation. Paul stresses two unshakeable pillars: there is only *one God*, and only *one mediator* – *"the man Christ Jesus"*. Because Jesus is fully God, he can represent God's holy presence; because he became fully human (*anthrōpos*), he can fully represent sinful humanity. No earthly priest, saint or angel can build this bridge; Christ alone bears the scars that sealed our reconciliation.
- **"A ransom for all" (*antilytron hyper pantōn* – ἀντίλυτρον ὑπὲρ πάντων, v. 6):** Christ *"gave himself as a ransom for all"*. The prefix *anti-* literally means "in the place of", and *lytron* is the ransom paid to buy a prisoner or slave free. Jesus' death on the cross was a substitutionary payment that wiped out the record of debt against us completely.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Intercession is the church's first civic duty.** The most powerful contribution the church can make to society happens in the place of prayer. When we pray for the world's leaders, we affect the spiritual atmosphere so that order is preserved and the gospel can spread freely.
2. **The gospel has a universal reach.** There is no one on earth – however wicked, powerful or ungodly – who stands outside the invitation of God's saving grace.
3. **Christ is the only mediator.** Every attempt to come to God by going around the person and finished work of Jesus is futile. He is not one way among many; he is the only bridge across the eternal gulf between sin and holiness.
4. **Salvation rests on a ransom paid.** Christ did not merely set an example; he gave himself as an *antilytron*. Our freedom was bought at great cost – with his own life.

Living It Out

We live in an age of extreme political polarisation, cynicism and social-media outrage. It is very easy to criticise, mock or speak with contempt about our leaders – presidents, ministers and officials – when they govern badly or pass laws that go against God's Word.

But Paul challenges us radically: **When did you last pray earnestly and sincerely for your leaders before you voiced your opinion about them?**

Christians are not called to fight the culture with worldly weapons, but to stand in the gap on our knees as intercessors. If we spend more time complaining about the state of our country than interceding for those who govern, we are acting against God's will.

This passage also reminds us of the foundation of our own security. You need no human go-between to come to God. If you have the Son, you have direct access to the Father. Christ is interceding for you now at God's right hand. This truth should move us to pray boldly for lost family members, neighbours and even enemies, knowing that God wants people *"to come to the knowledge of the truth"*.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Criticism or intercession?** If someone counted my words and my prayers about our civic leaders, which would weigh more: my criticism or my intercession?
- **Do I pray for my opponents?** Do I ever pray earnestly, even with tears, for people I deeply disagree with or who harm me, longing for them to taste God's salvation?
- **Whom do I trust?** Do I rely completely on Jesus as my only mediator – or am I still trying to prove my own righteousness through religious performance and good deeds?

Prayer

Heavenly Father, God of all grace and Ruler over the nations,

today I bow before you with a humble heart. I confess that I am often quicker to complain, judge and grow angry about the state of our world and the decisions of our leaders than to go down on my knees and plead for them.

Lord, today I bring our kings, presidents, judges and all in positions of authority before your throne. Give them godly wisdom, keep them from corruption and evil, and through their hands bring about order and justice, so that your people may live in peace. Create a climate in which your Word can run freely and hearts are opened to the gospel.

I praise and thank you for Jesus Christ, the one mediator, who gave himself as a ransom for my sins. Thank you that through him I have free access to your throne of grace. Use me today as a witness to this truth, and give me a heart that longs for the salvation of everyone around me.

In the exalted name of Jesus Christ, our Lord and Saviour. Amen.

DAY 5

An Attitude of Worship and Godliness

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 2:8–15

8 I want the men, then, to pray in every place, lifting up holy hands
without anger or quarrelling. 9 Likewise also the women should adorn
themselves in respectable clothing, with modesty and self-control, not
with braided hair and gold or pearls or expensive clothing, 10 but – as is
fitting for women who profess reverence for God – with good works. 11 A
woman should learn in quietness, in all submission. 12 I do not permit a
woman to teach, nor to exercise authority over a man; she is to be in
quietness. 13 For Adam was formed first, then Eve. 14 And Adam was not
deceived, but the woman was deceived and fell into transgression. 15 But
she will be saved through childbearing, if they remain in faith and love
and holiness, with self-control.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In the first half of chapter 2, Paul set out the worldwide reach of the church's prayer life and the unique mediation of Christ. Now he turns to the inner attitude and the visible order of believers in public worship ("in every place").

The church in Ephesus was struggling with particular cultural and spiritual imbalances that were disrupting its gatherings. On the one hand there were men who had caught the atmosphere of the false teachers – men who turned spiritual gatherings into arenas for aggressive debate, intellectual pride and mutual resentment. On the other hand there were wealthy women in Ephesus who carried the pagan culture of outward status display into the church. In the Greco-Roman world (and especially in the shadow of the Artemis cult in Ephesus), rich women showed off their

social superiority with extravagant hairstyles braided with gold and pearls, and with clothes that cost thousands of denarii. In addition, the false teachers in Ephesus were promoting ascetic ideas that despised marriage and motherhood (see 1 Timothy 4:3), while urging some uninstructed women to take over authority in the church loudly and to spread false teaching (see 1 Timothy 5:13; 2 Timothy 3:6–7).

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

A careful look at the Greek text sheds clear light on this much-debated passage:

- **"Holy hands" (*hosious cheiras* – ὁσίους χεῖρας, v. 8):** In the ancient world it was common to pray standing, with hands stretched out towards heaven. Paul insists that these must be "holy hands". The word *hosios* does not refer to ceremonial or ritual purity (like washing hands with water) but to moral integrity and a life devoted to God. These hands are to be lifted "without anger or quarrelling": without *orgē* (inner resentment or wrath) and without *dialogismos* (disputing, sceptical arguing, wrangling). You cannot reach towards heaven with one hand while clenching a fist against your brother with the other.
- **"With modesty and self-control" (*aidous kai sōphrosynēs* – αἰδοῦς καὶ σωφροσύνης, v. 9):** Women are called to adorn themselves with "modesty" (*aidōs* – a holy reverence and respect that refuses to draw improper attention to oneself) and "self-control" (*sōphrosynē* – sound judgement, self-mastery and inner balance). Paul does not forbid neatness or beauty; he condemns the temptation to turn worship into a fashion parade of wealth and sensuality. True adornment lies in "good works" (*ergōn agathōn*).
- **"A woman should learn in quietness" (*en hēsychia manthanetō* – ἐν ἡσυχίᾳ μανθανέτω, v. 11):** In an ancient culture where women were often considered unfit for deep theological instruction, Paul gives a revolutionary command in the imperative: *manthanetō* – "let her learn!" Women are fully included as disciples and students at the feet of Christ.

The word for "quietness" (*hēsychia*) has exactly the same root Paul used in verse 2 for the "peaceful and quiet life" all believers are to pray for. It does not mean a humiliating, enforced muteness, but a peaceful, receptive and teachable spirit that is not unruly.

- **"To exercise authority over a man" (*authentein* – αὐθεντεῖν, v. 12):** The word we translate "exercise authority" occurs only here in the whole New Testament. In Greek outside the Bible, *authentein* can mean to claim authority on one's own initiative, to domineer, or to wield autocratic power over someone. Paul anchors spiritual order and leadership responsibility in the church not in cultural chauvinism but in the order of creation (Genesis 2–3): Adam was formed first, as covenant head, and when that order was reversed at the fall, it led to ruin.
- **"But she will be saved through childbearing" (*sōthēsetai dia tēs teknogonias* – σωθήσεται διὰ τῆς τεκνογονίας, v. 15):** This verse has to be read in the light of Paul's whole theology. First, it certainly does not mean that a woman earns eternal justification by physically giving birth – that would directly contradict Paul's gospel of grace alone (1:14–16; 2:5–6). The verse has a double richness:
  1. *Against the ascetic false teachers:* While false teachers forbade marriage and urged women to reject their God-given nature in order to claim male leadership roles, Paul affirms that women live out their sanctification and salvation in practice ("saved" from the snare of false teaching and the curse of Eve's deception) by remaining faithful, in faith, love and holiness, in the God-given calling of womanhood, motherhood and caring for the family.
  2. *The messianic echo*: The Greek literally reads *dia tēs teknogonias* – "through *the* childbearing", with the definite article. Many interpreters point out that Paul is looking back here to the promise to the woman in Genesis 3:15: although Eve fell into transgression, God promised that salvation would break into the world through *the offspring of the woman* – the birth of the Messiah, Jesus Christ.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Holiness and reconciliation are prerequisites for powerful prayer.** God does not listen to the eloquence of our lips when our hearts are full of unforgiveness, anger and quarrelsomeness (see Matthew 5:23–24).
2. **True beauty is measured by service, not status.** In God's kingdom a garment of mercy and good works carries infinitely more weight than earthly wealth or physical attractiveness.
3. **Spiritual order promotes freedom and growth.** God's design of complementary roles for men and women in the church is not a matter of superiority or inferiority (Galatians 3:28), but of harmonious, ordered service that honours the order of creation.
4. **Sanctification happens in our everyday calling.** We do not serve God by rebelling against the season or calling in which he has placed us, but by remaining in it in faith, love and self-control.

Living It Out

This passage holds up a sharp mirror to both men and women in our modern consumer culture.

For **men** (and every believer who leads in prayer): our culture often celebrates the man who talks loudly, wins debates, vents his anger – and sits passively in church while he fights outside it. Paul turns this upside down. He calls men to be active intercessors in every place, but he demands that their lives be pure and their hearts free of anger and quarrelling. A man's spiritual strength lies not in his ability to argue but in his ability to kneel before God with clean hands and a gentle, reconciled heart.

For **women** (and every believer seduced by the image obsession of our age): we live in an era of social media, vanity and self-promotion, in which a person's worth is often measured by appearance, brands and

power. Paul sets believers free from this exhausting race. He reminds us that outward glamour fades, but a life clothed in kindness, wisdom, teachability and good works shines with an eternal beauty.

Finally, this text challenges our attitude towards spiritual authority and teaching. Do we come to God's Word with a critical, rebellious spirit that always wants to argue and to rule – or do we come with *hēsychia*, a quiet, receptive heart that longs to be taught by God?

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **What stands between my lifted hands and God?** When I lift my hands or my heart to God in prayer, is there hidden anger, resentment or quarrelsomeness towards a fellow believer or family member that is blocking my prayers?
- **Where do I invest more?** Do I spend more time, money and emotional energy polishing my outward image before people than clothing my inner self with good works and godliness?
- **Am I teachable?** Do I have a sincere, humble and teachable spirit when God's Word is preached – especially when Scripture challenges my culture's ideas about power, status and order?

Prayer

> *Holy and righteous Father, you know the deepest motives of our hearts when we gather before you. You do not look at the outward show with which we try to impress people; you search our inmost being.*
>
> *I come to you today and ask you to cleanse my hands and my heart. Forgive me for every time I drew near to you while still clinging to anger, bitterness and quarrelsomeness towards others. Strip from me the urge always to be right and to win every argument, and give me a spirit of peace and reconciliation.*

Lord, keep me also from the vanity of this world. Free me from my dependence on human approval, status and outward display. Clothe me daily with modesty, sound judgement and a wealth of good works that glorify your name. Give me a quiet, receptive and teachable heart that bows with joy before your Word and your perfect order of creation. Let me remain in my daily calling in faith, love and holiness. In the name of Jesus Christ, our Saviour and King. Amen.

DAY 6

The Character of a Spiritual Leader (Overseers)

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 3:1–7

[1] This is a trustworthy saying: if anyone aspires to the office of overseer,
he desires a good work. [2] The overseer, then, must be above reproach,
the husband of one wife, sober-minded, self-controlled, respectable,
hospitable, able to teach, [3] not a drunkard, not violent but gentle, not
quarrelsome, not a lover of money, [4] one who manages his own house-
hold well and keeps his children in submission, with all dignity – [5] for if
someone does not know how to manage his own household, how will he
take care of God's church? – [6] not a recent convert, so that he does not
become conceited and fall into the condemnation of the devil. [7] He must
also have a good reputation with outsiders, so that he does not fall into
disgrace and into the devil's trap.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

The crisis in the church at Ephesus was, at heart, a leadership crisis. The false teachers who had infiltrated the church (see Acts 20:29–30) were probably already serving elders who abused the office for intellectual fame, quarrelling and financial gain (1 Timothy 6:5). To restore and protect the church, Timothy had to bring the standard for spiritual leadership back to God's original blueprint.

Paul begins with the second of his five "trustworthy sayings" in the Pastoral Letters: "This is a trustworthy saying: if anyone aspires to the office of overseer, he desires a good work." Yet it is striking that Paul's list of requirements has nothing to do with worldly measures such as social sta-

tus, wealth, academic degrees or charismatic eloquence. In God's kingdom, spiritual authority rests squarely on the foundation of tested, Christlike character.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text gives us a razor-sharp picture of this calling:

- **"The office of overseer … a good work" (*episkopēs, kalou ergou* – ἐπισκοπῆς / καλοῦ ἔργου, v. 1):** The word for overseer (*episkopos*, used interchangeably in the New Testament with *presbyteros*, elder; see Titus 1:5–7) literally means to watch over someone with careful attention. Paul stresses that it is a *kalon ergon* – a good, noble **work**. Spiritual leadership in the church is not an honorary title or a position of prestige, but a laborious calling to shepherding service.
- **"Above reproach" (*anepilēmptos* – ἀνεπίλημπτος, v. 2):** This word heads the list as the umbrella term under which all the other qualities fall. It is a picture from wrestling and literally means "on whom no one can get a hold". It does not imply sinless perfection, but a life of such visible integrity that no enemy of the gospel can bring a valid, provable charge of shameful conduct.
- **"The husband of one wife" (*mias gynaikos andra* – μιᾶς γυναικὸς ἄνδρα, v. 2):** Literally a "one-woman man". In a Greco-Roman culture where affairs, temple prostitution, concubines and serial divorce were considered completely normal for men, Paul demands undivided marital faithfulness. A leader's eyes, heart and body must belong to his own wife alone.
- **"Sober-minded, self-controlled, respectable" (*nēphalion, sōphrona, kosmion* – νηφάλιον, σώφρονα, κόσμιον, v. 2):** These three related terms form a triad of inner and outward self-control. *Nēphalios* means clear-headed and spiritually alert (not dulled by excess); *sōphrōn* describes a balanced, disciplined mind; and *kosmios* (from which we get *cosmos*, as opposed to *chaos*) refers to an orderly, honourable way of life that makes inner harmony visible.

- **"Able to teach" (*didaktikos* – διδακτικός, v. 2):** This is the only skill on the list that distinguishes the overseer from the deacon. It does not simply mean speaking ability, but the spiritual ability to handle Scripture rightly, to pass on sound teaching patiently and to refute false teaching effectively.
- **"Gentle ... not a lover of money" (*epieikē*, *aphilargyron* – ἐπιεικῆ / ἀφιλάργυρον, v. 3):** In contrast to a drunkard (*paroinos*) and a violent man (*plēktēs* – someone who bullies others physically or with sharp words), the overseer must be *epieikēs*: gentle, gracious, yielding and willing to give up his own rights for the sake of peace. He must also be *aphilargyros* – free from the love of money, because greed corrupts spiritual judgement.
- **"How will he take care of God's church?" (*epimelēsetai* – ἐπιμελήσεται, v. 5):** Paul uses the verb *epimeleomai* here. It is exactly the word Jesus uses in Luke 10:34–35 to describe how the good Samaritan lovingly took care of the wounded man. The church is not a corporation to be managed, but a family and a hospital to be cared for with fatherly tenderness.
- **"Not a recent convert ... conceited" (*neophyton*, *typhōtheis* – νεόφυτον / τυφωθείς, v. 6):** A leader must not be a *neophytos* – literally "newly planted", a young shoot in the faith. If an immature believer is put into a position of authority too quickly, he runs the risk of becoming *typhōtheis* (from *typhos*, "smoke" or "mist"): puffed up and blinded by the smoke of conceit – and so he falls into the same condemnation that struck the devil when he exalted himself in pride.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Who you are always weighs more than what you can do.** God cares far more about a servant's holiness and self-control than about his outward talents or abilities.

2. **The family is the leader's real testing ground.** You can wear a Sunday-morning mask in public for a few hours, but at home all pretence falls away. The way someone lovingly leads his marriage and children reveals his true capacity for pastoral care.
3. **Spiritual maturity takes time and testing.** Knowledge can be gained quickly, but humility and spiritual backbone are forged only through time and the storms of life.
4. **The credibility of the gospel stands or falls with our witness to outsiders.** A leader "must have a good reputation with outsiders". Hypocrisy in business or society dishonours the name of Christ and becomes the enemy's trap.

Living It Out

It is a common temptation to read 1 Timothy 3:1–7 simply as a checklist for pastors and elders, and to let ourselves off the hook if we don't hold such an office. But apart from the specific gift of teaching, every quality on this list is expected elsewhere in the New Testament of **every believer.** These verses simply describe what spiritual maturity in Christ looks like.

We live in a culture dazzled by charisma, charm, fame and outward success. Even in the church, people are often put on platforms because they are dynamic speakers, successful businesspeople or influential personalities – while their lack of integrity, their temper or their neglected families are overlooked. Church history is littered with the wreckage of ministries in which gifting was exalted above character.

This passage calls each of us back to the basics. How do you handle conflict when someone opposes you – are you "violent" with sharp words, or are you *epieikēs*, gentle and gracious? Are your home and your table open to strangers and the lonely? Is your life driven by the chase for money and possessions, or by contentment in God? And above all: does the person your spouse and children see every day behind closed doors match the person who sits in the pew on Sunday?

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **How do I measure spiritual success?** Do I measure it in my own life (and in the people I admire) by visible gifts and achievements, or by the quiet, tested fruit of the Spirit?
- **What does my home say about me?** If the atmosphere in my home and the way I treat those closest to me were the only measure of my walk with God, what witness would it give today?
- **What do outsiders see?** What impression do unbelieving colleagues, neighbours and the people I do business with have of my character – do they see the honesty, peace and grace of Christ in how I act?

Prayer

Heavenly Father, Chief Shepherd of our souls, I bow before you in deep reverence for the holy standard you set in your Word. You are not impressed by human fame, outward show or smooth words; you look for hearts that are pure, humble and wholly devoted to you.

Today I pray first for the spiritual leaders, elders and pastors of your church. Keep them from the snares of the enemy – from pride, greed and moral compromise. Clothe them with wisdom, gentleness and incorruptible integrity, so that they care for your flock with the tenderness of Christ.

Lord, search my own heart too in the light of this passage. Forgive me where I have cared more about my reputation with people than about my character before your face. Heal me of a quarrelsome spirit, of impatience and selfishness. Make me a person of peace, hospitality and self-control. Help me to let my witness begin within the walls of my own home, and let my life before outsiders be so clean and sincere that your name is never dishonoured because of me. In the name of Jesus Christ, the Good Shepherd. Amen.

DAY 7

Faithful Service and Integrity (Deacons)

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 3:8–13

8 Deacons likewise must be dignified, not double-tongued, not given to
much wine, not greedy for dishonest gain, 9 holding the mystery of the
faith with a clear conscience. 10 And let them also be tested first; then let
them serve, if they prove blameless. 11 Women likewise must be digni-
fied, not slanderers, sober-minded, faithful in all things. 12 Deacons
must each be the husband of one wife, managing their children and
their own households well. 13 For those who have served well gain a
good standing for themselves and great confidence in the faith that is in
Christ Jesus.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Having set out the requirements for overseers (elders) – those called to lead the church through preaching the Word and pastoral oversight – Paul now turns to the second formal office in the local church: the deacons. Where the overseer's focus is mainly spiritual oversight and teaching, the deacon focuses on practical mercy, physical care and visible service within the community of faith.

The historical roots of this office lie in Acts 6:1–6. When the early church in Jerusalem grew and the daily care of the Greek-speaking widows was being neglected, the apostles appointed seven men "full of the Holy Spirit and wisdom" to oversee the tables and resources. In this way the apostles could devote themselves to prayer and the ministry of the Word, while the body of Christ was cared for in practical ways. In Ephesus this ministry was of critical importance. Deacons had access both to the church's funds

for the poor and to the private world of vulnerable members in their homes. That is why Paul demands the same high moral integrity of deacons as of overseers.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text sheds rich light on the nature of this calling:

- **"Deacons" (*diakonos* – διάκονος, v. 8):** The word literally means a servant, a waiter at tables, or someone who kicks up dust in his hurry to carry out an errand. In Greek culture *diakonia* was regarded as demeaning work for slaves. But Jesus Christ ennobled and crowned this idea when he said that he did not come to be served but to serve (*diakonēsai*) and to give his life (Mark 10:45). A deacon represents the heart and hands of the serving Christ.
- **"Not double-tongued" (*mē dilogous* – μὴ διλόγους, v. 8):** Literally "not two-worded" (*di* = two; *logos* = word). It describes someone who says one thing to one person and tells a completely different version to someone else, to manipulate people or win favour. Because deacons went from house to house to relieve need, a double-tongued person would quickly sow distrust and division in the church.
- **"Not greedy for dishonest gain" (*mē aischrokerdeis* – μὴ αἰσχροκερδεῖς, v. 8):** This compound word (literally "shameful gain") describes someone so eager for material profit that he is willing to sacrifice his honour and principles for money. Deacons managed the gifts for widows and orphans; a heart enslaved to greed would give in to the temptation to steal from the poor (like Judas Iscariot in John 12:6) or to favour rich members over poor ones.
- **"The mystery of the faith" (*to mystērion tēs pisteōs* – τὸ μυστήριον τῆς πίστεως, v. 9):** Deacons are to be "holding the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience". In the New Testament a *mystērion* is not an obscure riddle, but a divine truth that was hidden for ages and has now been fully revealed in Jesus Christ – the gospel. Paul here breaks down the

false division between "practical people" and "theological people". Even those who set tables and keep the accounts must be deeply rooted in sound teaching and live it out with a clean conscience.

- **"Let them also be tested first" (*dokimazesthōsan prōton* – δοκιμαζέσθωσαν πρῶτον, v. 10):** The verb *dokimazō* comes from metal-working and was used for testing precious metals like gold and silver in the fire to prove they were genuine. It is in the present tense, pointing to ongoing observation of a person's life. The church does not put people into office to see *whether* they will be faithful; it appoints people who have already shown, out of sight, that they *are* faithful.
- **"Women ... not slanderers" (*gynaikas ... mē diabolous* – γυναῖκας ... μὴ διαβόλους, v. 11):** Whether Paul is referring here to women deacons (like Phoebe in Romans 16:1) who served especially among women, children and the sick, or to the wives of deacons who supported their husbands in this sensitive ministry – the Greek *gynaikas* can mean either – the character requirement is the same: they must not be "slanderers" (*diabolous*). Strikingly, *diabolos* is exactly the Greek word translated elsewhere as "devil" (the slanderer, the accuser). When you see other people's weaknesses and household needs up close and spread that confidential information as gossip, you are literally doing the enemy's work.
- **"A good standing and great confidence" (*bathmon kalon, pollēn parrēsian* – βαθμὸν καλόν / πολλὴν παρρησίαν, v. 13):** Paul ends with a powerful promise for faithful service. Those who serve well gain a *bathmos kalos* (literally a good step or rung – a place of high spiritual respect and influence) and *pollē parrēsia*, "great confidence". *Parrēsia* means an unshakeable freedom, certainty and boldness to speak of Christ without fear or shame.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Practical service requires spiritual depth.** In God's eyes there is no "secular" or second-class task in the church. Relieving practical need calls for people who understand and live the mystery of the gospel.
2. **Our tongue and our wallet are mirrors of our soul.** How we talk about people when others aren't listening (*not double-tongued, not slanderers*) and how we handle money (*not greedy for dishonest gain*) show how deeply the gospel has changed our hearts.
3. **Character is tested in the hidden furnace.** God promotes no one who has not first been found faithful in the small, unseen things (Luke 16:10).
4. **The way up always leads down.** True spiritual authority and confidence in the faith are not gained by self-promotion but by humble, persevering service.

Living It Out

In our modern world, success is measured by how high you can climb the corporate or social ladder so that other people can serve *you*. We look for titles, platforms and recognition. Even in the church a subtle hierarchy sometimes develops, in which the person with the microphone on stage is considered more important than the person who sets out the chairs, manages the finances with integrity, or takes a meal to a sick member's home.

Paul demolishes this worldly thinking. He shows us that you never look more like Jesus than when you put on an apron and serve others selflessly.

But this passage challenges not only our willingness to serve; it also challenges the **integrity with which we serve**. Look especially at Paul's warning about our words: *not double-tongued* and *not slanderers*. How easily does it happen that we agree with one group's criticism, and ten minutes later say exactly the opposite to another group in order to stay popular?

Or how often is sensitive information we discover while helping someone passed on as a "prayer request" that is really just gossip in disguise? When we slander, we lend our tongues to the *diabolos*.

If you long for more confidence (*parrēsia*) in your life of faith – if you feel your prayer life and witness are powerless – verse 13 offers a surprising key: start serving other people in Jesus' name faithfully, quietly and with a clear conscience. Confidence in the faith blossoms where selfishness dies.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Do I serve where no one is watching?** Am I willing to serve joyfully in tasks where no one sees or thanks me, or do I serve only when it brings me status and recognition?
- **Am I "single-tongued"?** Can people be absolutely sure that I say the same about them behind their backs as to their faces, and that their secrets are safe with me?
- **What metal comes out?** If God put my present life through his fire test (*dokimazō*) – faithfulness in little things, honesty with money, care at home – what would remain?

Prayer

> *Lord Jesus Christ, you are King of the universe, and yet you came to wash our feet and to give your life as a ransom. Today I bow in wonder before your humility. Forgive me for the pride of my own heart, which so often looks for honour, comfort and recognition, while I shrink back from the unseen, sacrificial work of serving.*
>
> *Lord, cleanse my lips and my heart. Free me from a double tongue that tries to please people at the cost of the truth. Keep me from ever becoming an instrument of slander or gossip; make me a safe harbour of grace and trust-*

worthiness for the people you send across my path. Purify me also of every form of greed and dishonest gain, so that I hold the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience.

Test my heart, O God, and make me faithful in the small, everyday tasks – in my home, at my work and in your church. Give me the joy of serving you in such a way that I walk in confidence and unshakeable certainty in the faith. In your precious name, you who came to serve. Amen.

DAY 8

The Pillar of Truth and the Mystery of Godliness

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 3:14–16

14 I am writing these things to you, though I hope to come to you soon,
15 so that, if I am delayed, you may know how one ought to behave in the household of God, which is the church of the living God, a pillar and foundation of the truth. 16 And beyond all question, great is the mystery of godliness:

He was revealed in the flesh,
vindicated by the Spirit,
seen by angels,
proclaimed among the nations,
believed in throughout the world,
taken up in glory.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

These three verses form the theological heartbeat and overall aim of the whole of First Timothy. Having addressed the false teachers (chapter 1), called the church to worldwide prayer and reverent worship (chapter 2), and laid down the character requirements for overseers and deacons (3:1–13), Paul now pauses to explain *why* all these things are of eternal importance. He hopes to visit Timothy in Ephesus soon, but if he is delayed, these written apostolic instructions are to serve the church as a lasting charter.

To grasp the tremendous force of Paul's imagery in verses 15 and 16, we need to picture the physical setting of Ephesus. The pride of the city was the colossal Temple of Artemis (Diana) – one of the Seven Wonders of the Ancient World. The building was many times larger than the Parthenon in Athens. Its roof rested on 127 massive marble columns, each about eighteen metres high, many decorated with gold and carvings. Inside this breathtaking structure stood a dark, lifeless image of the goddess Artemis, which, according to tradition, had fallen from heaven. When the people of Ephesus felt threatened by the gospel, they shouted for hours in the theatre: *"Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!"* (Acts 19:28, 34).

Against this impressive pagan monument, Paul sets the local Christian congregation – a group of ordinary believers meeting in simple houses without any splendid church building – and describes them in language that completely eclipses the glory of Artemis.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **"The household of God" (*oikō theou* – οἴκῳ θεοῦ, v. 15):** This word carries a double meaning. First, it means God's **household or family**. That explains why Paul has just said that overseers and deacons must manage their own households well: the church is a spiritual family in which God is the Father and believers live together as brothers and sisters in love and order. Second, *oikos* refers to God's **dwelling or temple**. God does not live in temples of stone and marble made by human hands; he lives by his Spirit within his redeemed people (see Ephesians 2:19–22).
- **"The church of the living God" (*ekklēsia theou zōntos* – ἐκκλησία θεοῦ ζῶντος, v. 15):** While all of Ephesus bowed before a mute, dead idol in its marble palace, the God who lives among the gathered believers is the **living** Creator who hears, speaks, saves and renews.
- **"A pillar and foundation of the truth" (*stylos kai hedraiōma tēs alētheias* – στῦλος καὶ ἑδραίωμα τῆς ἀληθείας, v. 15):** A *stylos* (pillar) had two functions: it carried the weight of the roof, and it lifted the

beauty of the building high above the city so that everyone could see it from afar. A *hedraiōma* is the deep, unshakeable foundation or buttress that keeps the structure from collapsing in an earthquake. Notice the order: the church does not create or define the truth; the truth does not rest on the church's opinions. On the contrary, the church is the servant of the truth – called to guard the gospel unchanged, to protect it from false teaching, and to hold it high like a torch before a dark world.

- "**And beyond all question, great is the mystery of godliness" (*homologoumenōs mega estin to tēs eusebeias mystērion* – ὁμολογουμένως μέγα ἐστὶν τὸ τῆς εὐσεβείας μυστήριον, v. 16):** Against the pagan cry "*Great (megalē) is Artemis!*" Paul declares: "Beyond all question" (*homologoumenōs* – literally "as everyone confesses together"), "**great** (*mega*) is the mystery of godliness!" What is the mystery that produces true godliness (*eusebeia*) in a person's life? Not a human philosophy or a list of legal rules – but a Person!
- **The six-line hymn to Christ (v. 16):** Paul quotes here a rhythmic, poetic confession of faith from the early church. In Greek it consists of six short lines, each beginning with a powerful past-tense verb, arranged in three pairs of contrasts between heaven and earth. Our translation begins "**He** was revealed in the flesh", whereas older Bibles (such as the King James Version) read "**God** was manifest in the flesh". The oldest and best Greek manuscripts have *hos* ("he who"); the later reading *theos* ("God") probably arose because the two words look very similar in the ancient capital-letter script. The meaning stays the same: the "He" is the Person the whole hymn celebrates – Jesus Christ, the eternal Son who became man.
  1. "*He was revealed in the flesh*" (ἐφανερώθη ἐν σαρκί): The incarnation. In the Son, the eternal, invisible God took on a true human nature and came to live visibly among us.

2. "*Vindicated by the Spirit*" (ἐδικαιώθη ἐν πνεύματι): The resurrection and vindication. Although the world condemned Jesus on a cross as a blasphemer and criminal, the Holy Spirit raised him from the dead and so proved that he truly is the sinless Son of God (see Romans 1:4).
3. "*Seen by angels*" (ὤφθη ἀγγέλοις): Cosmic triumph. The heavenly hosts watched his birth, his suffering, his resurrection and his victory over the powers of darkness with awe.
4. "*Proclaimed among the nations*" (ἐκηρύχθη ἐν ἔθνεσιν): Worldwide mission. The message of salvation broke through every ethnic boundary to be proclaimed to the nations.
5. "*Believed in throughout the world*" (ἐπιστεύθη ἐν κόσμῳ): Saving fruit. In the midst of a hostile, fallen world, the gospel broke open hearts and awakened true faith.
6. "*Taken up in glory*" (ἀνελήμφθη ἐν δόξῃ): The ascension and enthronement. The humbled Servant has been exalted to the highest place of honour at the Father's right hand.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Our conduct in the local church reflects our reverence for God.** How we behave in the church – our prayers, our leadership, our love and order towards one another – is no side issue, because the church is the holy household of the living God.
2. **The church's highest calling is faithfulness to the truth.** When a church waters down biblical truth to fit the spirit of the age, it loses its reason to exist as *pillar and foundation*.
3. **Christology is the fountain of all ethics.** True godliness (*eusebeia*) can never be produced by mere human willpower; it flows from a constant wonder at who Jesus Christ is and what he has done.

4. **History belongs to the glorified King.** Christ did not merely die on a cross; he lives, he is believed in throughout the world, and he already reigns in glory.

Living It Out

We live in an age of extreme individualism, even among Christians. It has become common to hear people say: *"I love Jesus, but I don't need the church; my faith is a private matter between me and God."* Others treat the local church like a spiritual shopping centre or a theatre – somewhere you go when it suits you, to see whether the music and the sermon are to your taste, without any commitment or responsibility.

Paul's words in 1 Timothy 3:15 jolt us back to reality. You cannot claim to love the Head (Christ) while despising or neglecting his body and his household (the church). To God, the local church is so precious that he calls it his own dwelling on earth. More than that: he has designed no "Plan B" for holding up the truth of the gospel in your community; he has appointed the local church as the pillar and foundation of his truth.

At the same time, verse 16 gives us the secret of perseverance. We have now reached the middle of the letter. Looking back over everything we have learned in chapters 1 to 3 – the fight for sound teaching, a clear conscience, self-giving love, persistent intercession, a holy life and humble service – we can easily feel overwhelmed by our own shortcomings. Where does anyone find the strength to live like this?

Paul shows us the answer: **Look away from yourself and fix your eyes on the Person of Jesus Christ.** The secret of a godly life is that your heart is overwhelmed by the gospel every day: that the eternal Son became flesh for you, that his resurrection has acquitted you, and that he now intercedes for you in glory. When Christ becomes great in your eyes, sin becomes small and obedience becomes a joy.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **How do I see my church?** Do I regard and treat my local church as a consumer service that should serve me, or as the precious household of the living God in which I carry a holy responsibility?
- **Do I hold up the truth?** Do my daily life and my words help to hold up the truth of God's Word like a firm pillar, high and visible before a lost world?
- **Where do I draw my strength from?** Do I try to squeeze spiritual growth and godliness out of my own strength, or do I draw new strength every day by pausing in worship at the cross, the resurrection and the glory of Jesus Christ?

Prayer

Living and almighty God, Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, halfway through this letter I bow today in deep awe before your throne. You are not a distant, dead idol made by human hands; you are the living God who in grace chose to dwell among your people and to call us your own household.

Forgive me, Lord, for every time I have thought or spoken lightly about your church. Forgive me where I have been selfish in my involvement in the body of Christ. Help me to fill my place in the church with humility, love and devotion. Make our church an unshakeable pillar and foundation of your truth in a world that has lost its way in lies and darkness.

And today, Lord Jesus, I want to cry out with the church of every age: Great is the mystery of godliness! I worship you, who were revealed in the flesh to save me. I praise you that you were vindicated by the Spirit when you conquered the grave. I praise you that your name is proclaimed among the nations, that you have awakened faith in my heart too, and that you now reign in eternal glory. Let the beauty of who you are so fill my heart that my whole life becomes an offering of praise and true godliness. In your mighty, glorified name. Amen.

DAY 9

A Warning against Falling Away and False Piety

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 4:1–5

[1] Now the Spirit says explicitly that in later times some will fall away
from the faith, devoting themselves to deceiving spirits and teachings of
demons, [2] through the hypocrisy of liars whose own consciences have
been branded. [3] They forbid marriage and demand abstinence from
foods that God created to be received with thanksgiving by those who
believe and know the truth. [4] For everything created by God is good, and
nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving, [5] for it is
made holy by the word of God and prayer.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday, at the end of chapter 3, Paul took us up to a breathtaking summit with the early church's hymn about "the mystery of godliness" – Jesus Christ, who "was revealed in the flesh" and now reigns in glory (3:16). But at the start of chapter 4 the apostle brings us straight back down to the harsh reality of the spiritual battlefield. The contrast could hardly be sharper: over against the glory of the truth stands the dark threat of falling away.

In Ephesus a subtle but poisonous false teaching had taken root – an early forerunner of Gnosticism, mixed with Jewish legalism (see Titus 1:14–15). These false teachers taught that the physical, material world is inherently evil or inferior, and that true spiritual enlightenment can only be reached through *asceticism* – strict abstinence from earthly things such as mar-

riage and certain foods. At first sight it looked deeply pious, disciplined and holy. But Paul tears off the mask and exposes the demonic source behind it.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text reveals how serious this spiritual deception is:

- **"Explicitly" (*rhētōs* – ῥητῶς, v. 1):** The Spirit speaks "explicitly" (*rhētōs*) – in unmistakable, crystal-clear, openly stated terms. So the church need not be surprised or shocked when people abandon the truth "in later times". Paul is thinking of the age the church already lives in: the time between Christ's first coming and his return. God has warned us in advance through Christ and the apostles (see Matthew 24:11, 24; Acts 20:29–30).
- **"Fall away from the faith" (*apostēsontai* – ἀποστήσονται, v. 1):** The verb *aphistēmi*, from which we get *apostasy*, means to deliberately stand away, to veer off course, to desert to the enemy. It describes people who outwardly belonged to the visible community of faith and knew the truth, yet turn their backs on the gospel.
- **"Deceiving spirits and teachings of demons" (*pneumasi planois kai didaskaliais daimoniōn* – πνεύμασι πλάνοις καὶ διδασκαλίαις δαιμονίων, v. 1):** Why do people fall away? Because they lend their ears to deceiving spirits. The word *planos* (related to our word *planet* – a "wandering star") describes something that lures you off the right path into a maze. Paul shows that false theology is never neutral, never merely an innocent human mistake. Behind every teaching that twists the gospel and God's created order stands an evil, demonic reality.
- **"Whose own consciences have been branded" (*kekaustēriasmenōn tēn idian syneidēsin* – κεκαυστηριασμένων τὴν ἰδίαν συνείδησιν, v. 2):** These liars live in "hypocrisy" (*hypokrisis* – play-acting) because their conscience has been branded. The verb *kaustēriazō* means to burn with a red-hot iron. It carries two vivid images. First, when skin is burned with a hot iron, thick scar tissue forms in which the nerve endings are

dead – it becomes numb. In the same way these people have ignored their conscience for so long (see 1:19) that they no longer feel guilt when they lie. Second, in the ancient world slaves and criminals were branded to show whom they belonged to. Their consciences bear the ownership mark of another master.

- **"They forbid marriage" (*kōlyontōn gamein, apechesthai brōmatōn* – κωλυόντων γαμεῖν, ἀπέχεσθαι βρωμάτων, v. 3):** By forbidding marriage and rejecting foods, the false teachers attack God as Creator head-on. In effect they claim to be holier than God, who instituted marriage in Genesis 1 and 2, gave food, and declared his creation "very good". Paul says it plainly: "Everything created by God is good" (*kalon*, v. 4).
- **"Made holy by the word of God and prayer" (*hagiazetai dia logou theou kai enteuxeōs* – ἁγιάζεται διὰ λόγου θεοῦ καὶ ἐντεύξεως, v. 5):** "The word of God" refers to God's revelation (such as Genesis 1:29–31 and Jesus' words in Mark 7:19 declaring all foods clean), which gives the believer freedom to enjoy God's creation. "Prayer" (*enteuxis*) is the believer's grateful acknowledgement at the table that every piece of bread and every blessing comes from the Father's hand.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Our discernment must be anchored in Scripture, not in outward appearance.** Not everything that looks religious, strict or self-sacrificing comes from God. The devil often disguises himself as an angel of light, using outward legalism to lead people away from grace.
2. **A numbed conscience is the most dangerous state a person can be in.** When someone keeps sinning against God's truth against their better knowledge, the nerves of the conscience are burned away until spiritual blindness sets in.
3. **Creation and redemption belong together.** You cannot honour the Redeemer while rejecting the good gifts of the Creator – the holiness of marriage, the care of the body – as unclean.

4. **Thanksgiving is the antidote both to legalism and to excess.** The ascetic legalist rejects God's gifts; the worldly person greedily misuses them. The true believer receives them with humble gratitude, through the word and prayer.

Living It Out

What do "deceiving spirits" and false piety look like in our own day? We are attacked from two directions.

On one side, modern ideologies try to dismantle and redefine God's good created order regarding marriage, sexuality and the human body. As in Ephesus, this is often presented as "enlightened thinking" or "higher wisdom" – but in reality it is a rejection of the Creator's design.

On the other side, believers are still in danger of falling into the trap of legalistic piety. How easily we create our own lists of man-made rules and prohibitions that are not in Scripture, and then use them as the yardstick for who is "spiritual" and who is not. In Colossians 2:20–23 Paul warns against rules such as *"Don't handle! Don't taste! Don't touch!"* – they have an appearance of wisdom and humility, but no power to change our sinful nature.

True holiness is not found in fleeing from God's creation, but in receiving every good gift of God on his terms and with a thankful heart. When we pray together before a meal, it should never be an empty, rattled-off rhyme. It is a deep confession of faith: we declare that God is the Creator and Giver of all things, and we dedicate even our daily bread and our earthly relationships to him as offerings of gratitude.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Do I continually test the books I read, the teachings I listen to and the cultural currents around me against the authority of God's Word – or am I easily carried along by ideas that sound new and impressive?

- Is my conscience still tender and responsive to the conviction of the Holy Spirit today – or are there areas where repeated compromise has begun to form "scar tissue"?
- Is my daily life – from the food on my table to the relationships in my home – marked by sincere, prayerful thanksgiving to my Creator?

Prayer

Almighty Creator and loving Father, you are the source of all life, all light and all truth. In the beginning you made the heavens and the earth and declared that everything you had made was very good. I praise you for your fatherly goodness, which surrounds me every day with so many undeserved gifts.

Lord, we live in times when many voices are calling and deceiving teachings lure people away from the simple truth of the gospel. I pray today for spiritual discernment through your Holy Spirit. Guard my mind from lies that dress themselves up as piety or wisdom. Above all, guard my heart from ever becoming numb or branded in my conscience; keep my inner life tender, breakable and quick to bow before your Word.

Forgive me where I have taken your good gifts for granted without thanking you, or set man-made rules above your grace. Sanctify my home, my table, my marriage and my everyday life today through your Word and through a life of constant prayer and thanksgiving. In the name of Jesus Christ, through whom all things were made and in whom our redemption stands firm. Amen.

DAY 10

Train Yourself for Godliness

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 4:6–10

6 If you put these things before the brothers and sisters, you will be a
good servant of Christ Jesus, nourished on the words of the faith and of
the good teaching that you have followed. 7 But have nothing to do with
irreverent, old wives' myths. Rather, train yourself for godliness. 8 For
bodily training is of little value, but godliness is of value in every way,
holding promise for the present life and for the life to come. 9 This is a
trustworthy saying and deserves full acceptance. 10 For to this end we
toil and are reviled, because we have set our hope on the living God,
who is the Saviour of all people, especially of those who believe.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In verses 1 to 5 Paul exposed the false asceticism of the false teachers – people who thought true holiness came from forbidding marriage and certain foods. Now he shows Timothy what genuine spiritual discipline looks like. Paul does not reject discipline as such; he rejects only *misplaced*, legalistic discipline that has no eternal value.

To drive his point home, Paul reaches for an image every resident of Ephesus would grasp at once: the Graeco-Roman *gymnasion* and the world of athletics. Ephesus was known for its sports facilities and for the regular games held in honour of Artemis. Young men trained for hours under strict coaches, pushing their bodies to the limit to win a fading laurel wreath. Paul takes this cultural obsession with physical training and turns it into a powerful picture of the Christian life.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text unfolds rich images of nourishment, training and endurance:

- **"If you put these things before..." (*hypotithemenos* – ὑποτιθέμενος, v. 6):** To be a "good servant" (*kalos diakonos*) of Christ Jesus, Timothy must put these truths before the brothers and sisters. The verb *hypotithēmi* literally means to set something carefully in front of someone (like a nourishing meal on a table) or to lay a firm foundation under someone's feet. A true spiritual leader does not bully or manipulate the flock as the false teachers did; he patiently serves them with the truth.
- **"Nourished" (*entrephomenos* – ἐντρεφόμενος, v. 6):** This participle is in the present tense and describes an ongoing, daily process of nourishment. No athlete can perform without the right diet, and no servant of God can feed others spiritually while their own soul is starving. Timothy's menu consists of "the words of the faith" and "the good teaching that you have followed" (*parēkolouthēkas* – like someone following step by step in a teacher's footsteps).
- **"Irreverent, old wives' myths" (*bebēlous kai graōdeis mythous* – βεβήλους καὶ γραώδεις μύθους, v. 7):** Over against the healthy diet of the Word stands spiritual junk food. *Bebēlos* describes what is profane, worldly and without any sacred value. *Graōdēs* ("old-womanish") was a common expression among Greek philosophers for superstitious, unprovable stories and pointless speculation. Timothy must firmly "have nothing to do with" such *mythoi* (*paraiteomai* – to refuse even to listen to them).
- **"Train yourself for godliness" (*gymnaze seauton pros eusebeian* – γύμναζε σεαυτὸν πρὸς εὐσέβειαν, v. 7):** Here Paul uses the imperative of *gymnazō*, which gives us *gymnasium* and *gymnastics*. In the ancient world athletes trained naked (*gymnos*) so that no heavy clothing would hinder them, and they built their muscles with sweat and sacrifice.

Paul is saying that godliness (*eusebeia* – a life of deep reverence and practical obedience towards God) never happens by accident or by itself. It requires deliberate, disciplined spiritual effort.

- **"Bodily training is of little value" (*pros oligon estin ōphelimos* – πρὸς ὀλίγον ἐστὶν ὠφέλιμος, v. 8):** Paul does not say that caring for and exercising the body is useless or wrong. He says its value is limited (*pros oligon*), because its benefits apply only to this short earthly life and end at the grave. The value of godliness, by contrast, spans two worlds: it holds "promise for the present life and for the life to come".
- **"We toil and are reviled" (*kopiōmen kai oneidizometha* – κοπιῶμεν καὶ ὀνειδιζόμεθα, v. 10):** For this eternal goal we toil (*kopiaō* – to work to the point of physical and emotional exhaustion) and are reviled (*oneidizō* – to endure insult and mockery; some ancient manuscripts read *agōnizometha* here, "we struggle as in an arena"). What gives a believer the strength to sweat like this and bear reproach? Our hope is set "on the living God".
- **"The Saviour of all people, especially of those who believe" (*sōtēr pantōn anthrōpōn, malista pistōn* – σωτὴρ πάντων ἀνθρώπων, μάλιστα πιστῶν, v. 10):** In his common goodness God sustains, preserves and provides for all people every day with life and breath, and his offer of salvation is open to all (see 2:4). But in a very particular, eternal way (*malista* – especially, above all) he gives complete and final salvation to those who believe in Christ.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Healthy ministry flows from healthy personal nourishment.** You cannot pour from an empty cup. Before you can put God's truth before others, your own heart must be filled with Scripture every day.
2. **Grace does not rule out spiritual effort; it fuels it.** We are saved by grace alone, yet that very grace calls us to train in holiness, prayer and obedience with the dedication of a top athlete.

3. **An eternal perspective sets our priorities.** It is folly to invest all our time and energy in caring for a temporary earthly tent while our immortal soul is neglected.
4. **Our hope in the living God is the fuel of perseverance.** When our eyes are fixed on the promises of the living God, earthly exhaustion and human mockery become light to carry.

Living It Out

We live in a culture obsessed with the physical body, wellness and outward appearance. Billions are spent every year on gym memberships, strict diets, vitamins, running shoes and cosmetics, trying to halt the ageing process. There is nothing wrong with being good stewards of our bodies – Paul does grant that bodily training has *some* value, for a short while.

The tragedy is the imbalance. How many Christians would never miss their morning run or their gym session, and count every calorie, while their Bibles lie closed under a layer of dust week after week? We build muscles for a body that will return to dust, while our spiritual muscles waste away for the eternity that lies ahead.

Look at your **spiritual diet**, too (vv. 6–7). What do you feed your mind every day? If you scroll through social media for hours, stuffing yourself with political quarrels, conspiracy theories, worldly entertainment and the modern "old wives' myths" of our day, don't be surprised if your faith feels weak and your spirit anxious.

To train yourself for godliness (*gymnazō*) means building deliberate spiritual habits – even on days when you don't "feel like it". An athlete doesn't train only when inspired; he trains according to a fixed discipline. In the same way, spiritual fitness requires us to lift the heavy weights every day: meditating on the Word, persevering in prayer, self-denial, forgiveness and service. The reward is beyond compare: peace and character in this life, and indescribable glory in the life to come.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- If I compare the time and energy I spend on my body, my appearance and earthly comfort with the time I give to spiritual training (Bible study, prayer and service), what picture does that paint of my real priorities?
- What do I "feed" my soul during the week – the words of the faith, or the empty calories of worldly entertainment, news obsession and pointless arguments?
- Which spiritual discipline in my life has slackened, and is asking today for a new, deliberate decision to start "training" again?

Prayer

Living God, my Creator, my Saviour and my eternal hope, I come to you today aware of how easily my priorities slip. Forgive me, Lord, that I so often give my best time, my sharpest thinking and most of my energy to things that matter only for this short, passing life, while I neglect the training of my soul.

Lord Jesus, awaken in me a deep, unquenchable hunger for the words of the faith and for good teaching. Guard my mind and my eyes from the empty, irreverent stories and distractions of this world that steal my spiritual strength. Feed me daily with the living bread of your Word, so that I may grow strong and be a blessing to others.

Holy Spirit, give me the discipline of a spiritual athlete. Help me to throw off every weight and the sin that so easily entangles me, and to train with perseverance in true godliness. When the road grows steep, when I am worn out by the work, or when people revile me for my faith, keep my eyes fixed on your promises – for today and for the eternity ahead. In the name of Jesus Christ, the pioneer and perfecter of our faith. Amen.

DAY 11

An Example in Speech and Conduct (Keep Watch on Yourself)

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 4:11–16

11 Instruct people in these things and teach them. 12 Let no one look
down on you because of your youth, but set the believers an example in
speech, in conduct, in love, in faith, in purity. 13 Until I come, devote
yourself to the public reading of Scripture, to exhortation and to teach-
ing. 14 Do not neglect the gift that is in you, which was given to you
through prophecy when the council of elders laid their hands on you.
15 Put these things into practice, give yourself wholly to them, so that
your progress may be evident to all. 16 Keep a close watch on yourself
and on your teaching; persist in them. For by doing this you will save
both yourself and those who hear you.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In this personal and searching paragraph Paul turns his full attention to Timothy's heart, his way of ministering and his personal walk with God. Timothy faced a double challenge in Ephesus: he not only had to confront seasoned, eloquent false teachers, but had to do so as a relatively young man in a culture that held age and seniority in high regard.

In the Graeco-Roman and Jewish world a man could still be counted as "young" (*neotēs* – youth) until about forty. Timothy was probably in his early to mid thirties. For proud older members of the church in Ephesus it was easy to look down on him and wave away his authority: "*Who is this young man to come and teach us*?" But Paul shows Timothy that the answer to such contempt does not lie in a show of power, aggression or self-righteousness, but in undeniable spiritual maturity and a transparent life.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text holds a treasury of pastoral and practical wisdom in these six verses:

- **"Look down on" and "example" (*kataphroneitō* – καταφρονείτω; *typos* – τύπος, v. 12):** *Kataphroneō* literally means to look down on someone in your mind. How does Timothy overcome this? By being a *typos* – an "example" – for the believers. A *typos* was the impression a stamp or signet ring left in soft wax, or a pattern from which something is shaped. Before Timothy could shape the church with his words, his own life had to bear the visible imprint of Jesus Christ. Paul names five areas of life in which this imprint must show (later manuscripts also add "in spirit", as in older translations):
  - *In speech* (ἐν λόγῳ): every conversation – from the pulpit to a casual chat – marked by truth, grace and building up.
  - *In conduct* (ἐν ἀναστροφῇ): his daily behaviour, habits and integrity, even when no one is watching.
  - *In love* (ἐν ἀγάπῃ): unconditional, self-giving care that puts the interests of others above his own.
  - *In faith* (ἐν πίστει): steadfast faithfulness and trust in God in the face of opposition.
  - *In purity* (ἐν ἁγνείᾳ): moral and sexual purity – not only in outward actions but down to the deepest motives of the heart (see 5:2).
- **"To the public reading of Scripture, to exhortation and to teaching" (*anagnōsis*, *paraklēsis*, *didaskalia* – ἀνάγνωσις, παράκλησις, διδασκαλία, v. 13):** Here we have one of the earliest glimpses of the ministry of the Word in Christian worship, taken over directly from synagogue practice. First comes *anagnōsis* – the public reading of Scripture aloud (then the Old Testament and the letters of the apostles), since most believers had no copies of their own. Then *paraklēsis* –

exhortation and encouragement that addresses heart and will and moves them to action. And then *didaskalia* – teaching that explains in an orderly way what the text means.

- **"Do not neglect the gift that is in you" (*mē amelei tou en soi charismatos* – μὴ ἀμέλει τοῦ ἐν σοὶ χαρίσματος, v. 14):** When Timothy was set apart for ministry – through prophecy and the laying on of hands by the council of elders – the Holy Spirit equipped him in a particular way (*charisma*). But a gift from God does not run automatically like a machine. If it is neglected (*ameleō*) out of fear, intimidation or laziness, its effectiveness withers.
- **"Give yourself wholly to them" and "progress" (*en toutois isthi* – ἐν τούτοις ἴσθι; *prokopē* – προκοπή, v. 15):** Where our translation says "give yourself wholly to them", the Greek literally says: *"Be in these things!"* It means immersing your whole being in them until they become the air you breathe. The result is that your progress (*prokopē*) will be evident to all. The word is often explained with the picture of pioneers cutting a path through dense forest so that others can follow. A spiritual leader need not pretend to be perfect already, but the church should be able to see that he is steadily moving forward in his walk with God.
- **"Keep a close watch on yourself and on your teaching" (*epeche seautō kai tē didaskalia* – ἔπεχε σεαυτῷ καὶ τῇ διδασκαλίᾳ, v. 16):** The verb *epechō* means to fix your undivided attention on something and keep watchful guard over it. Notice the order: **first on yourself**, **then on the teaching**. A preacher or believer who carefully checks his doctrine but neglects his own soul and secret sin is heading for disaster. Conversely, whoever focuses only on personal piety without sound teaching drifts into subjective error. Where both are guarded together, God uses that faithfulness to carry "both yourself and those who hear you" safely through to eternal salvation.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Character bridges every credibility gap.** True spiritual authority does not come from age, titles or position, but from a life that, like a clear stamp (*typos*), imprints the image of Christ in speech, love and purity.
2. **Scripture is the beating heart of the church.** Without the faithful reading, clear explanation and searching application of God's Word, the church loses her compass and her spiritual power.
3. **Spiritual growth should be visible and alive.** No one has reached the finishing line yet. Even the most experienced believer or leader is called to constant *prokopē* (spiritual progress) that spurs others on.
4. **Watching over yourself comes before serving others.** You cannot serve others spiritually while your own walk with the Lord is neglected. Watchfulness over your own heart and over sound truth cannot be separated.

Living It Out

This passage speaks powerfully to each of us, whatever our age or our role in the kingdom.

Perhaps today, like Timothy, you feel inadequate or looked down on. Perhaps you are young in years, or young in the faith, or you find yourself at work or in a family where people look down on you. The temptation is always either to shrink back into silence or to try hard and aggressively to prove you have authority. Paul shows a better way: **live in such a way that your character silences your critics.** When your words are soaked in grace, your work ethic is above reproach, your love is genuine and your moral purity is beyond suspicion, your witness gains a weight that no one can ignore.

For those of us who have walked with the Lord for decades, verse 15 raises a serious question: **can the people around you still see that you are making progress?** One of the greatest dangers for older believers is spiritual

stagnation – living off the manna of spiritual experiences from twenty years ago. When our children, grandchildren and younger believers look at us, do they see someone still hungry for the Word, still growing in gentleness, still living with passion for the Lord?

Finally, the wake-up call of verse 16 rings out like a bell over our hurried lives: *"Keep a close watch on yourself!"* Just as an airline passenger must put on their own oxygen mask before they can help the child beside them, you must first watch over your own soul. It doesn't help to be busy with church work, ministry or caring for your family if your own inner room is empty and your own heart is cooling towards Jesus.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Of the areas Paul names in verse 12 (speech, conduct, love, faith, purity), which is currently the weakest link in my daily example to others?
- Is there a spiritual gift or calling God has placed in my life that I am currently neglecting out of fear, comfort or busyness?
- If the people closest to me compared me today with who I was five years ago, would they see clear spiritual progress (*prokopē*) and growth in Christlikeness?

Prayer

> *Lord Jesus Christ, my perfect example and the shepherd of my soul, thank you for the clear mirror of your Word. I confess today that I am so often more concerned about how people see and respect me than about the real state of my heart before you. Forgive me where my words, my impatient behaviour or my lack of love have clouded the picture of who you are for others.*
>
> *Lord, press your stamp deep into my life again. Make me a living example for the people around me – purify my speech, sanctify my daily conduct, fill me with your self-giving love, and keep my thoughts and my body in com-*

plete purity. Where the fire of your gifts in me has burned low through neglect or fear, fan it into flame again today by the breath of your Spirit.

Keep me from spiritual standstill and lukewarmness. Grant that I may go so deep into your Word that my spiritual growth will encourage everyone. Help me today to keep careful watch over my own soul and over the truth of your gospel, so that I persevere to the end. In your holy and precious name. Amen.

DAY 12

Spiritual Family Ties and Caring for Widows (Part 1)

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 5:1–8

[1] Do not rebuke an older man harshly, but encourage him as you would a father, younger men as brothers, [2] older women as mothers, younger women as sisters, in all purity.

[3] Honour widows who are truly widows. [4] But if a widow has children or grandchildren, let them first learn to show godliness towards their own household and to repay their parents, for this is pleasing before God. [5] The one who is truly a widow and left all alone has set her hope on God and continues in petitions and prayers night and day. [6] But the one who lives for pleasure is dead while she lives. [7] Instruct them in these things too, so that they may be above reproach. [8] But if anyone does not provide for his own relatives, and especially for members of his household, he has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In 3:15 Paul described the local church as "the household of God" (*oikos theou*) – God's own family. Now, at the beginning of chapter 5, he shows Timothy how this spiritual family is to work in practice. When a young leader is called to correct wrong behaviour and false teaching in the church, there is always a danger that he will either rule with a dictator's whip or treat people merely as "cases" and problems. So Paul anchors all pastoral care in the warmth and respect of family relationships: fathers, mothers, brothers and sisters.

Straight after this Paul turns to one of the greatest social challenges in the early church: the care of widows. In the Graeco-Roman world there were no state pensions, no life insurance, no health funds and no welfare benefits. If a woman lost her husband and had no adult children or relatives to support her, she faced extreme poverty and hunger. From its beginnings in Jerusalem (Acts 6:1) the Christian church took up the care of widows as a holy calling, grounded in the character of God, who introduces himself in the Old Testament as the "defender of widows" (Psalm 68:5). But in Ephesus some families had begun to exploit this mercy, offloading their own elderly mothers and grandmothers onto the church's shoulders.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text reveals the richness and sharpness of Paul's instructions:

- **"Do not rebuke ... harshly, but encourage him" (*mē epiplēxēs, alla parakalei* – μὴ ἐπιπλήξῃς, ἀλλὰ παρακάλει, v. 1):** The verb *epiplēssō* literally means to strike at someone – with words that land like blows. Even when an older man in the church is in the wrong and must be corrected, Timothy may never humiliate him or trample on his dignity. He is to *parakaleō* him – to come alongside and appeal to him with the respect and tenderness with which a son would speak to his own father.
- **"In all purity" (*en pasē hagneia* – ἐν πάσῃ ἁγνείᾳ, v. 2):** Younger women are to be treated as sisters, "in all purity". In a sexually permissive city like Ephesus, this short phrase was a vital safeguard. *Hagneia* means not only the absence of physical immorality but complete purity of thought, gaze and motive. When a spiritual leader (and every man in the church) sees the women of the church as precious sisters in Christ to be protected, every hint of flirtation or emotional manipulation is nipped in the bud.
- **"Honour widows who are truly widows" (*chēras tima tas ontōs chēras* – Χήρας τίμα τὰς ὄντως χήρας, v. 3):** In this chapter the verb *timaō* ("honour") has a double meaning: to hold someone in high esteem and

to support them financially (see v. 17, where "honour" is linked with pay). The word for widow (*chēra*) is often connected with a root meaning "bereft, stripped". The one who is "truly a widow" (*ontōs chēra*) is, according to verse 5, *memonōmenē* – literally "left all alone", with no child, grandchild or relative to care for her.

- **"Show godliness ... and repay their parents" (*eusebein ... kai amoibas apodidonai* – εὐσεβεῖν ... καὶ ἀμοιβὰς ἀποδιδόναι, v. 4):** If a widow does have children or grandchildren, the first duty rests with them. They are to learn "to show godliness towards their own household" (*eusebeō* – the same word family as *eusebeia*) and "to repay their parents" (*amoibas apodidonai* – to make a return that is owed). Your parents fed you, carried you and cared for you when you were a helpless baby; caring for them in their vulnerable old age is not a favour you do them but the repayment of a sacred debt, in keeping with the fifth commandment (Exodus 20:12).
- **"Dead while she lives" (*spatalōsa zōsa tethnēken* – σπαταλῶσα ζῶσα τέθνηκεν, v. 6):** Over against the godly widow who turns her loneliness into a ministry of unceasing prayer (like the prophetess Anna in Luke 2:36–37), Paul sets the widow who *spatalaō* – a word for luxurious pleasure-seeking and extravagance used to fill the emptiness of the heart. Paul passes a shocking verdict on such a life: though she still breathes (*zōsa*), she is spiritually dead (*tethnēken*).
- **"He has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever" (*tēn pistin ērnētai kai estin apistou cheirōn* – τὴν πίστιν ἤρνηται καὶ ἔστιν ἀπίστου χείρων, v. 8):** Whoever refuses to provide for their own relatives and household (*pronoeō* – to think ahead and make practical provision) "has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever". Why worse than a pagan? Because even unbelieving Greeks and Romans knew that children were obliged to support their elderly parents. When a professing Christian – who boasts in the self-giving love of Jesus on the cross – lets his own family suffer in need, he makes the gospel a lie in the eyes of the world.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The church is a spiritual family where respect and purity set the tone.** How we speak with and treat older and younger generations in the church should reflect God's father-heart and holy character.
2. **The home is the first classroom of true godliness.** God does not accept pious churchgoing or religious giving as a substitute for loving care of our own elderly parents and family members (see Mark 7:10–13).
3. **Loss and loneliness can become a sanctuary of intercession.** When earthly supports fall away and a believer's hope is set wholly on God, their prayers night and day become one of the most powerful spiritual engine rooms of the church.
4. **Practical lovelessness is a form of denying the faith.** Faith is denied not only by false teaching on the lips, but just as effectively by a hard heart and a closed hand towards the people under your own roof.

Living It Out

This passage cuts deep into the fabric of our modern Western culture. We live in a society that idolises youth, productivity and independence, while elderly people are often seen as a burden and pushed into the background.

First, look at how we speak to one another across the generations (vv. 1–2). On social media and even in church meetings we often see younger people speak of the older generation with contempt and sharp words – or older people speak dismissively of the young. Paul calls us back to family respect: see in an older believer a spiritual father or mother, and treat a younger believer with the protective love and complete purity you would show your own brother or sister.

Second, verses 4 and 8 directly challenge our responsibility for our families. Although today we have care homes and retirement villages that provide valuable medical and physical care, this never releases children and grandchildren from their God-given duty. To honour your parents and

"repay" them means more than making sure their bills are paid; it means giving them time, emotional presence, dignity and love. How tragic it is when elderly parents waste away in loneliness month after month while their children are "too busy" with careers, hobbies or even church activities to visit or support them! Paul says it plainly: it is pleasing before God when we carry our parents in their weakness, as they carried us when we were small.

Finally, verses 5 and 6 offer deep comfort and a warning to anyone going through a season of loneliness, widowhood or loss. When life strips you of a spouse or loved ones, you stand at a crossroads: you can try to numb the pain by living for pleasure (through worldly entertainment, bitterness or self-absorption), which kills your soul spiritually – or you can let your whole weight rest on the living God and turn your aloneness into a precious ministry of intercession.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Do my words and attitude towards older people speak of the respect due to a father or mother – and do I treat the opposite sex, in thought and action, with the complete purity owed to a brother or sister?
- What does my practical, financial and emotional care for my own parents, grandparents and family members look like at the moment – does God see in it a sincere offering of thanks that pleases him?
- When I experience loneliness or loss, do I run to shallow distractions that dull me spiritually, or does it drive me into a deeper, persevering life of prayer before God?

Prayer

> *Heavenly Father, father of the fatherless and defender of widows, I bow before you today with gratitude that you have not left us as orphans in this world, but through the blood of Jesus have adopted us into your own spiri-*

tual family. Forgive me where I have treated fellow believers with harshness, impatience or a lack of respect, instead of loving them as fathers, mothers, brothers and sisters.

Lord, cleanse my heart and my eyes so that all my relationships are marked by complete purity. I pray today especially for my own family and household. Keep me from the hypocrisy of looking pious outside my home while neglecting the people you have entrusted to my care. Show me how to honour, support and cherish my parents, grandparents and family in practical ways that are pleasing to you.

I also bring before you today every widow, widower and lonely person in our church. Be a shield to them and a source of unshakeable hope, and strengthen them as they pray before you night and day. In the loving name of Jesus Christ, our elder brother and Redeemer. Amen.

DAY 13

True Widows and Devoted Service (Part 2)

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 5:9–16

9 Let a widow be put on the list if she is not less than sixty years old, the
wife of one husband, 10 and well known for good works: if she has
brought up children, if she has shown hospitality, if she has washed the
feet of the saints, if she has helped the afflicted, if she has devoted her-
self to every good work. 11 But refuse younger widows; for when their
desires draw them away from Christ, they want to marry, 12 and so incur
condemnation for having set aside their first faithfulness. 13 Besides
that, they learn to be idle, going round from house to house; and not
only idle, but also gossips and busybodies, saying what they should not.
14 So I want younger widows to marry, to have children, to manage their
households, and to give the adversary no occasion for slander. 15 For
some have already turned aside to follow Satan. 16 If any believing
woman has widows in her family, let her help them, and let the church
not be burdened, so that it may help those who are truly widows.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In verses 3 to 8 Paul laid down the general principles for the care of needy widows by their own families. In verses 9 to 16 he turns to a very specific group in the early church: the official "list" or order of widows. This is not simply about emergency relief for a woman who is going hungry for a while – any destitute widow would be helped by the church anyway. It is about a permanent place on the congregation's register of support, which went hand in hand with a formal commitment to spiritual service.

These enrolled widows were supported by the church for life, and in return they devoted their remaining years to intercession, caring for orphans and the sick, teaching younger women and works of mercy. In Ephesus, however, a serious problem had arisen. Younger widows had been put on this permanent list and had probably taken a vow not to remarry. As time passed, three things happened. First, the natural desire to marry again returned, and they broke their promise to the church. Second, the church's financial support meant they no longer had to work, and they drifted into idleness. Third, the false teachers – who forbade marriage (4:3) – used these idle young widows to go from house to house and spread their false teaching (see 2 Timothy 3:6).

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text gives us a razor-sharp insight into Paul's pastoral wisdom:

- **"Put on the list" (*katalegesthō* – καταλεγέσθω, v. 9):** This verb was a technical term for drawing up an official register of names, such as a military roll or a citizens' list. In the ancient world, sixty was regarded as the threshold of old age, after which a woman rarely remarried and was therefore free to devote herself fully to the Lord's service. She also had to have been "the wife of one husband" (*henos andros gynē*) – literally a "one-man woman", the exact female counterpart of the requirement for overseers and deacons in 3:2, 12. It describes a life of unwavering marital faithfulness and purity.
- **"If she has washed the feet of the saints" (*ei hagiōn podas enipsen* – εἰ ἁγίων πόδας ἔνιψεν, v. 10):** Before a widow was placed on this roll of honour, her past had to show five practical forms of love: she had brought up children (*eteknotrophēsen* – her own or abandoned orphans), she had shown hospitality (*exenodochēsen*), she had helped the afflicted (*thlibomenois epērkesen*), she had devoted herself to every good work – and she had "washed the feet of the saints". Washing someone's dusty feet was the lowest slave's work in the ancient East, but Jesus

himself raised it to the highest symbol of cross-shaped humility (John 13:14). It is a picture of someone who was never too important for the dirtiest, most unseen service to fellow believers.

- **"When their desires draw them away from Christ" and "first faithfulness" (*katastrēniasōsin / prōtēn pistin* – καταστρηνιάσωσιν / πρώτην πίστιν, vv. 11–12):** Paul tells Timothy not to put younger widows on this permanent list. The verb *katastrēniazō* is a vivid picture of a well-fed animal growing restless, kicking against the harness and wanting to break out of its pen. When their natural longing for marriage becomes overwhelming, they set aside their "first faithfulness" (*prōtēn pistin*). This refers to their solemn promise of lifelong, unmarried service to Christ and the church – or in some cases perhaps even their confession of faith, if they married an unbeliever in order to be provided for.
- **"Idle ... gossips and busybodies" (*argai, phlyaroi kai periergoi* – ἀργαί, φλύαροι καὶ περίεργοι, v. 13):** Here Paul sketches the slippery slope of unused time. First they become *argai* – idle, without purposeful work. Then they become *phlyaroi* – an onomatopoeic word that sounds like a pot boiling over; it describes people overflowing with empty chatter and gossip. Then they become *periergoi* – "busybodies". In Greek this is a brilliant play on words: instead of working (*ergazomai*), they "work around" (*peri*) other people's affairs, poking their noses into other households.
- **"Manage their households" and "occasion" (*oikodespotein / aphormēn* – οἰκοδεσποτεῖν / ἀφορμήν, v. 14):** Against the ascetic false teachers, who treated marriage as second-rate, Paul gives younger widows a positive charge: let them marry, have children and "manage their households" (*oikodespotein*). This word literally means to act as the master or manager of a household – it gives great dignity and authority to a woman's leadership in her home. In this way they "give the adversary

no occasion" (*aphormē*) for slander. An *aphormē* is a military term for a bridgehead or base of operations from which an enemy launches an attack.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **True greatness lies in hidden, humble service.** When God describes a life of spiritual excellence (v. 10), he mentions neither fame nor position, but children brought up, an open front door, washed feet and comforted hearts.
2. **Mercy without discernment can do harm.** Releasing people financially from their God-given responsibility to work, or to be cared for by their family, breeds spiritual laziness and robs those who are truly helpless (v. 16).
3. **Idleness is never neutral.** A person who does not invest time and energy in an upbuilding calling quickly becomes an instrument of division, gossip and spiritual wandering.
4. **Faithfulness in our everyday calling disarms the enemy.** Every time a believer manages marriage, family and daily work with devotion, the enemy's military "bridgehead" of slander is destroyed.

Living It Out

This passage holds up two very practical mirrors to our modern lives.

First, look at **the CV of a godly life in verse 10.** How are you building a legacy today that counts for eternity? Our culture says you only have value if you hold a senior position, run big projects or have thousands of followers. That is why so many parents who spend their days raising children, or people who quietly care for the elderly and the sick behind the scenes, feel that their lives are "insignificant". Paul turns our value system upside down! In heaven's archives, the woman (and man) who faithfully

raises children in the fear of the Lord, opens their home to the lonely, is willing to "wash the feet of the saints" in humble service, and sits beside the broken in their affliction is counted among the noblest heroes of faith.

Second, look at Paul's warning about **idleness, gossip and being a busybody in verse 13**. In the first century you had to step out of your front door to go from house to house and poke your nose into other people's business. Today we don't even have to get off the sofa – we do it with our thumbs on our phones!

Social media has made it easier than ever to be spiritually *argos* (idle) and *periergos* (a busybody). Hours of precious time that could go to prayer, service or meaningful work are lost peering through the "digital windows" of other people's homes, discussing their lives, offering opinions on matters that are none of our business, and "saying what they should not" – and we do the same. When we become bored and spiritually inactive, we give Satan an *aphormē* – a foothold in our thoughts and in our churches. The antidote to a busybody spirit is to keep your hands full with the plough of your own calling and with acts of mercy.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- If my life today were measured by the standards of verse 10 – hospitality, the humble "foot-washing" of fellow believers, and helping the afflicted – what would my past testify?
- How do I use my free time and my words? Am I letting idleness or social media draw me into gossip and meddling in other people's affairs?
- Is there any area of my household or daily duties that I am neglecting, giving the enemy an "occasion" (*aphormē*) to slander the name of Christ?

Prayer

> *Heavenly Father, you see what is done in secret, and not one cup of cold water given in your name escapes your notice.*

I thank you that your measure of a fruitful life is so radically different from this world's. Thank you for the spiritual mothers and fathers in our lives who have carried us with their quiet, faithful prayers, their hospitality and their sacrificial love. Help us as a church to care with generous love for those who are truly alone and defenceless.

Lord Jesus, you tied a towel around your waist and washed your disciples' dusty feet – break my pride today. Make me willing to take on the lowliest tasks in your kingdom with joy. Give me eyes that see the afflicted and the lonely around me, and hands that are never too busy to help.

Keep me from the trap of spiritual idleness, Lord. Set a guard over my mouth and my eyes, so that I do not become guilty of empty chatter, gossip or meddling in things that are not my concern. Fill my days with purposeful zeal for every good work you have prepared for me, so that the adversary finds no foothold in my life or my home. In your wonderful and holy name. Amen.

DAY 14

Double Honour and Fair Discipline for Elders

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 5:17–25

17 Let the elders who lead well be considered worthy of double honour,
especially those who labour in preaching and teaching. 18 For the
Scripture says, "You shall not muzzle an ox while it is treading out the
grain," and, "The worker deserves his wages." 19 Do not accept an accusa-
tion against an elder except on the evidence of two or three witnesses.
20 Those who persist in sin, rebuke in the presence of all, so that the rest
may also stand in fear. 21 I solemnly charge you before God and Christ
Jesus and the chosen angels to keep these rules without prejudice, doing
nothing out of favouritism. 22 Do not be hasty in the laying on of hands,
and do not take part in the sins of others. Keep yourself pure. 23 No
longer drink only water, but use a little wine for the sake of your stom-
ach and your frequent illnesses. 24 The sins of some people are obvious,
going ahead of them to judgement, but the sins of others follow after
them. 25 So also good works are obvious, and even those that are not
cannot remain hidden.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Having explained in the first half of chapter 5 how the church should care for its widows, Paul now turns to a second group in the church's household that needs both financial support and careful oversight: the elders (*presbyteroi*).

We need to remember that the crisis in Ephesus had arisen precisely among the elders. Years earlier, on the beach at Miletus, Paul had warned the Ephesian elders that men would arise "from among your own selves"

speaking twisted things to draw away the disciples after them (Acts 20:30). By the time Paul writes this letter, that warning has come true (see 1 Timothy 1:19–20). Timothy therefore faced a sensitive and complex task: he had to honour and provide for faithful, hard-working elders; protect innocent leaders from malicious gossip; discipline sinning leaders without fear or favouritism; and prevent unsuitable men from being appointed too quickly to positions of leadership in the future.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text unfolds a masterpiece of spiritual oversight and pastoral care:

- **"Double honour" and "labour" (*diplēs timēs / kopiōntes* – διπλῆς τιμῆς / κοπιῶντες, v. 17):** Elders "who lead well" (*kalōs proestōtes* – those who go ahead with spiritual excellence and take care of others) are "worthy of double honour". Just as with the widows in verse 3, the word *timē* ("honour") includes both high esteem and tangible financial reward. "Double honour" does not mean they should be paid twice as much as a widow, but that they are owed both the respect of the church and a generous living. This applies especially to "those who labour in preaching and teaching" (*kopiaō* – to toil to the point of physical and spiritual exhaustion).
- **"For the Scripture says" (*legei gar hē graphē* – λέγει γὰρ ἡ γραφή, v. 18):** To support this financial provision, Paul quotes two texts under a single heading: "*For the Scripture says …*" The first quotation comes from the Old Testament (Deuteronomy 25:4 – the ox that may freely eat from the grain while doing the heavy work of threshing). The second ("*The worker deserves his wages*"), however, comes straight from the words of Jesus as recorded in Luke 10:7! This is a tremendous theological moment: already in the early sixties of the first century, Paul places the words of Jesus, as recorded in Luke's Gospel, on exactly the same level of divine authority ("the Scripture") as the books of Moses.

- **"Rebuke in the presence of all" (*enōpion pantōn elenche* – *ἐνώπιον πάντων ἔλεγχε*, vv. 19–20):** Because spiritual leaders are a constant target of the enemy, no accusation against an elder may be accepted on the basis of mere hearsay or one disgruntled person's word; it requires the biblical standard of two or three independent witnesses (Deuteronomy 19:15). But when an elder's sin is proven and he persists in it (*tous hamartanontas* – a present participle describing someone who keeps on sinning and refuses to repent), he must be rebuked "in the presence of all". Public leadership carries public accountability, so that a holy awe (*phobos*) may come over the whole church.
- **"Without prejudice ... out of favouritism" (*chōris prokrimatos ... kata prosklisin* – *χωρὶς προκρίματος ... κατὰ πρόσκλισιν*, v. 21):** Paul calls on the highest witnesses imaginable – God, Christ Jesus and the chosen angels who watch over the church – to bind Timothy to complete fairness. He may do nothing out of *prokrima* (prejudice – judging someone guilty in advance because you don't like them) or out of *prosklisis* (favouritism – literally leaning towards someone's side because he is your friend or an influential member).
- **"Do not be hasty in the laying on of hands" (*cheiras tacheōs mēdeni epitithei* – *χεῖρας ταχέως μηδενὶ ἐπιτίθει*, v. 22):** This refers to the formal commissioning or ordination of someone to the office of elder (see 4:14). If Timothy hastily appoints an untested man to a position of spiritual authority, and that man later wreaks havoc through false teaching or scandal, Timothy has taken part in the sins of others (*koinōnei* – literally, become a partner in them).
- **"No longer drink only water" (*mēketi hydropotei* – *μηκέτι ὑδροπότει*, v. 23):** Right after telling Timothy, *"Keep yourself pure"*, Paul adds a deeply fatherly remark: *"No longer drink only water ..."* The verb *hydropoteō* describes someone who has become a strict "water-drinker" on principle. Timothy had probably avoided all wine – in reaction to the drunkenness of some leaders (3:3, 8) and influenced by the ascetic climate in Ephesus – in order to keep his purity above suspicion. But

the impure water of the ancient world had affected his stomach and made him chronically ill. Paul lovingly corrects him: true purity (*hagnos*) lies in moral and spiritual integrity, not in neglecting your physical health. In ancient medicine a little wine was used to purify water and relieve stomach complaints.

- **"Obvious … follow after" (*prodēloi … epakolouthousin* – πρόδηλοι … ἐπακολουθοῦσιν, vv. 24–25):** With these last two verses Paul returns to why the laying on of hands must never be hasty. Some people's sins (and good works) are *prodēlos* – clear as day from the start, walking ahead of them, as it were. Others are masters at hiding their true nature; their sins (or their quiet, hidden good works) "follow after them" (*epakoloutheō*). But if you wait patiently and let time do its work, both the hidden wickedness of the hypocrite and the quiet godliness of the humble servant will eventually come to the surface.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Spiritual labour in the Word is noble but draining, and deserves generous support.** A church that financially neglects or emotionally belittles those who feed it with the gospel robs itself of spiritual blessing.
2. **Biblical justice balances protection with accountability.** The church must never be a breeding ground for unsubstantiated gossip about leaders – but neither may it become a hiding place where leaders' proven sins are swept under the carpet.
3. **Prejudice and cronyism are an abomination before the throne of heaven.** In God's house the same standard of holiness applies to everyone, regardless of position, wealth or friendships.
4. **Discernment requires patience.** Time and testing expose every false front and confirm every sincere character.

Living It Out

This passage speaks directly to the health of our churches today and to our personal relationships.

In modern church culture, people often fall into one of two dangerous extremes in how they treat spiritual leaders. On the one hand there are churches that treat their pastors and elders with a consumer mentality: they expect leaders to be available around the clock, pick apart the sermon over Sunday lunch, and listen eagerly to every unsubstantiated rumour or complaint from a single disgruntled member. Paul says: **Stop the gossip in its tracks!** Don't even entertain an accusation unless it is backed by reliable witnesses – and show "double honour" to those who pour out their strength to feed your soul with the Word.

On the other hand, we see today the tragic results of a "celebrity culture" in some churches, where prominent leaders are considered untouchable. When such leaders fall into serious moral or financial sin, their inner circle closes ranks out of favouritism (*prosklisis*) to cover up the scandal "so that the ministry doesn't suffer". Paul's solemn charge before God and the angels shatters this practice: when sin is covered up, the church loses its holy fear of God.

On a very personal level, verses 22 to 25 give each of us wisdom for everyday choices:

- **Don't trust or promote people too quickly.** Whether it's appointing a leader in the church, choosing a business partner or entering a marriage – don't be dazzled by a shiny first impression. Give it time. What is hidden today will be revealed tomorrow under the pressures of life.
- **Encouragement for the quiet worker.** Perhaps you feel that nobody notices your good works and sacrifices, while others who are louder get all the credit. Be assured of the promise in verse 25: even good works that are not yet obvious "cannot remain hidden". God sees them, and in his time he will bring them to light.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Do I show sincere honour, gratitude and support to those who labour to minister the Word to me – and do I protect their reputation when others speak ill of them without evidence?
- Is my judgement of other people truly free of *prokrima* (prejudice against people I don't like) and *prosklisis* (overlooking the faults of my friends and favourites)?
- Do I practise patient discernment before giving people my trust, my vote or my support – and do I watch daily over both my spiritual purity and the healthy care of my body?

Prayer

Holy and righteous God, you sit on the throne surrounded by thousands of angels, and you judge without favouritism.

I bow today in deep awe before your majesty. Thank you for the faithful shepherds, pastors and elders you have given to your church – people who wear themselves out studying and proclaiming your Word to feed our souls. Teach me to treat them with double honour, to pray for them, and never to lend my ear to malicious, unsubstantiated gossip that seeks to destroy their ministry.

At the same time I pray for a spirit of holy fear and incorruptible fairness in our church. Keep our leaders from pride and secret sin, and keep us from ever sweeping sin under the carpet out of fear of people or favouritism. Let your church be a place of light, truth and purity.

Lord, give me personally the wisdom of patience. Keep me from hasty decisions and shallow judgements about people, for I know that your eyes see through every mask and that time reveals everything. Keep my heart, my thoughts and my hands pure in the midst of a soiled world, and give me the

> *wisdom to care for my body too, as a serviceable temple for your glory. In the name of Jesus Christ, the righteous Judge and Head of the church. Amen.*

DAY 15

Contentment versus the Trap of the Love of Money

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 6:1–10

[1] Let all who are under the yoke as slaves regard their own masters as
worthy of all honour, so that the name of God and the teaching may not
be blasphemed. [2] Those who have believing masters must not look down
on them because they are brothers; rather, they must serve them all the
better, because those who benefit from their good service are believers
and beloved. Teach and urge these things.

[3] If anyone teaches a different doctrine and does not agree with the
sound words of our Lord Jesus Christ and with the teaching that ac-
cords with godliness, [4] he is puffed up and understands nothing. He has
an unhealthy craving for controversies and quarrels about words,
which produce envy, strife, slander, evil suspicions, [5] and constant fric-
tion among people who are corrupted in mind and deprived of the
truth, who think that godliness is a means of gain. [6] But godliness with
contentment is great gain. [7] For we brought nothing into the world, and
we cannot take anything out of it. [8] But if we have food and clothing,
with these we will be content. [9] But those who want to be rich fall into
temptation, into a trap, and into many senseless and harmful desires
that plunge people into ruin and destruction. [10] For the love of money is
a root of all kinds of evil. Some, by craving it, have wandered away from
the faith and pierced themselves with many pains.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

At the start of chapter 6, Paul rounds off his instructions for the different groups in the church by addressing the sensitive issue of slaves and their masters. In the first-century Roman Empire, slavery was the economic backbone of society; by some estimates a large part of the population of cities like Ephesus was enslaved. When a slave came to faith and heard that in Christ he was completely free and an equal brother (Galatians 3:28), the temptation arose to rebel against his master – or, if the master was also a Christian, to let his work slide and take advantage of their brotherhood. Paul knows that a violent social uprising at that time would have destroyed the young church and made the gospel look like nothing more than a political protest movement. So he calls slaves to do their work with such excellence and respect that the name of God is honoured – while hollowing out the institution of slavery from within by binding masters and slaves to one another as "brothers" and "beloved" (see the letter to Philemon).

From verse 3 on, Paul returns one last, devastating time to the false teachers in Ephesus. So far we have heard about their speculative genealogies (chapter 1) and their legalistic asceticism (chapter 4). Now Paul pulls back the final curtain and exposes the real motive behind their whole ministry: **they did it for money**. In the ancient world, travelling philosophers and orators often sought wealthy patrons and sold their lectures to fund a lavish lifestyle. The false teachers in Ephesus exploited the church in exactly the same way.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text exposes the sharp contrast between this corrupt pursuit of profit and true spiritual wealth:

- **"Sound words" versus "unhealthy craving" (*hygiainousi logois / nosōn* – ὑγιαίνουσι λόγοις / νοσῶν, vv. 3–4):** Paul sets "the sound words of our Lord Jesus Christ" (*hygiainō* – life-giving and wholesome) directly against the false teacher who has an "unhealthy craving" (*nosōn* – to be feverishly sick or spiritually obsessed) for controversies and "quarrels about words" (*logomachiai* – pointless hair-splitting). While sound teaching cultivates godliness and peace, the false teacher's obsession produces a poisonous harvest of envy, suspicion and "constant friction" (*diaparatribai* – rubbing one another raw, over and over).
- **"Gain" (*porismos* – πορισμός, vv. 5–6):** This business term means a profitable enterprise or a money-making scheme. False teachers see religion merely as *porismos* – a cash cow for personal enrichment and status. But Paul takes their favourite word and turns it on its head: "*But godliness with contentment is great gain*" (*porismos megas*). True, eternal gain does not lie in your bank balance but in your relationship with God.
- **"Contentment" (*autarkeia* – αὐτάρκεια, v. 6):** This was one of the highest virtues of Stoic philosophy, where it meant the pride of being completely "self-sufficient" and independent of all outward things and emotions. Paul takes over the word and baptises it in the grace of Christ. For the believer, *autarkeia* is not a cold self-sufficiency but **Christ-sufficiency** (see Philippians 4:11–13) – the deep inner peace of a soul that knows the Father provides, whether it has much or little in earthly possessions.
- **"Clothing" (*skepasmata* – σκεπάσματα, v. 8):** Where our translation speaks of "food and clothing", the Greek word *skepasmata* literally means "coverings". It includes both clothes to cover the body and a roof over your head. With these basic necessities, the pilgrim on the way to eternity can be content.

- **"Those who want to be rich" and "trap" (*hoi boulomenoi plousteinpagis* – οἱ βουλόμενοι πλουτεῖν / παγίς, v. 9):** Notice carefully that Paul does not say it is a sin to own money – in verse 17 he even addresses believers who are rich. The danger lies with *hoi boulomenoi plousteinpagis* – those who have made a settled decision of the will, who are obsessed and determined to get rich. They step into a *pagis* (a hidden bird-snare or trap), and their senseless desires "plunge" them (*bythizō* – to sink like an overloaded ship to the bottom of the sea) into ruin and destruction.
- **"Love of money" and "pierced" (*philargyria / periepeiran* – φιλαργυρία / περιέπειραν, v. 10):** "For the love of money (*philargyria* – literally love of silver) is a root of all kinds of evil." When money becomes your idol, there is no sin – from fraud and adultery to betrayal and murder – that it cannot lead to. Those who crave it (*oregomai*) wander away from the faith and have "pierced themselves with many pains" (*peripeirō*). This shocking Greek word means to skewer meat from every side on a spit. People think wealth will buy them a soft cushion of happiness, but in reality they are impaling their own souls on a sharp iron spit of anxiety, broken relationships and regret.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Our daily work is a direct witness to the gospel.** How a Christian works under authority – especially when the employer is also a believer – determines whether the world will honour God's teaching or blaspheme it.
2. **Any gospel that sells godliness as a means to material wealth is a false gospel.** The truth of Christ leads to holiness and humility, never to greed and self-enrichment.
3. **We stand between two nakednesses.** Like Job (Job 1:21), Paul reminds us that we came into the world empty-handed and will leave it through the grave empty-handed. Only what is invested in God goes with us through death.

4. **Contentment is the most powerful weapon against the lure of Mammon.** Whoever has found rest in God's provision cannot be bribed or caught by the world's glittering traps.

Living It Out

This passage cuts like a two-edged sword through two of the greatest temptations of modern life: our attitude at **work** and our relationship with **money**.

First, look at verses 1 and 2. Although we do not live in the Roman slave system today, most of us spend the greater part of the week in a workplace under the authority of a manager, a board or clients. What is your work ethic like? If your colleagues know you are a Christian, but you arrive late, constantly complain about the boss or hand in half-finished work, the name of God is blasphemed because of you. And if you work for a fellow believer, Paul warns against the subtle trap of making less effort "because we're brothers in the Lord, after all". On the contrary: precisely because your employer is beloved by Christ, you should give your very best service!

Second, look at the masterful diagnosis of our consumer culture in verses 3 to 10. Every day we are bombarded by thousands of advertisements designed to kill one particular virtue in your heart: **contentment**. The world whispers ceaselessly: "*You don't have enough yet. If only you had that bigger house, that newer car or that higher salary – then you would be happy.*" Even in parts of today's church a so-called "prosperity gospel" is preached that does exactly what Paul warns against in verse 5: it teaches that godliness is simply a lever for getting rich.

Paul calls us to wake up before the trap of *philargyria* (love of money) snaps shut around our feet. A hearse never tows a trailer. When you breathe your last, your portfolio, your property and your earthly status stay behind. How tragic it is when people neglect their families, sell their conscience and deny their faith in the mad chase after wealth – only to

discover at the end of their lives that they have pierced their own hearts with untold pain! True wealth is looking this morning at the food on your table and the clothes on your back, and being able to say with a deep, grateful smile: "*Lord, because I have you, I have enough.*"

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Do my punctuality, honesty and dedication at work reflect such a high standard that they make the gospel of Jesus Christ attractive and credible to my employer and colleagues?
- Am I living today in true *autarkeia* (contentment in God's provision), or are my mood and peace determined by what I still want to buy and how much money is in my account?
- Is there any area where the desire to get ahead financially is tempting me right now to sacrifice my integrity, my family time or my devotion to the Lord?

Prayer

> *All-sufficient God and heavenly Father, Creator and Owner of the universe,*
>
> *I came into this world with empty hands, and with empty hands I will one day stand before your throne. Everything I have today – every bite of food, every piece of clothing, the roof over my head and the breath in my lungs – is an undeserved gift from your Father's hand.*
>
> *Forgive me, Lord, for the ingratitude and restlessness of my own heart. Forgive me where I have let myself be swept along by this world's obsession with money, possessions and earthly security. Keep my soul from the deadly trap of the love of money, which has made so many people sink into spiritual ruin and pierce themselves with pain.*
>
> *Lord Jesus, plant the precious jewel of true contentment deep within me today. Teach me that your presence and your grace are my greatest gain. Bless the work of my hands this week too: help me to carry out my daily du-*

ties with such respect, integrity and zeal that your holy name and your teaching are honoured through them. In your rich and mighty name alone. Amen.

DAY 16

Flee, Pursue, Fight – and Guard What Has Been Entrusted

SCRIPTURE

1 Timothy 6:11–21

11 But you, man of God, flee from these things. Pursue righteousness,
godliness, faith, love, endurance, gentleness. 12 Fight the good fight of
the faith. Take hold of the eternal life to which you were called and
about which you made the good confession in the presence of many wit-
nesses. 13 I charge you before God, who gives life to all things, and before
Christ Jesus, who in his testimony before Pontius Pilate made the good
confession, 14 to keep the commandment spotless and above reproach
until the appearing of our Lord Jesus Christ,

15 which he will display at the proper time –
he who is the blessed and only Sovereign,
the King of kings and Lord of lords,
16 who alone has immortality,
who dwells in unapproachable light,
whom no one has ever seen or can see.
To him be honour and eternal dominion. Amen.

17 As for the rich in this present age, instruct them not to be arrogant,
nor to set their hope on the uncertainty of riches, but on God, who
richly provides us with everything to enjoy. 18 They are to do good, to be
rich in good works, to be generous and ready to share, 19 so storing up
for themselves a good foundation for the future, so that they may take
hold of the life that is truly life.

20 O Timothy, guard what has been entrusted to you. Turn away from ir-
reverent, empty chatter and the contradictions of what is falsely called
knowledge, 21 which some have professed and so have swerved from the
faith. Grace be with you all.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With these stirring closing verses, Paul reaches the summit of his first letter to Timothy. Having described in verses 3 to 10 the tragic fate of the false teachers, swallowed up by the love of money and quarrels about words, he draws a sharp dividing line in verse 11: "*But you, man of God …*"

This form of address – **man of God** (*anthrōpe theou*) – is used as a title for a person in the New Testament only here and in 2 Timothy 3:17. In the Old Testament, "man of God" was the highest title of honour for God's prophetic messengers such as Moses, Samuel, Elijah, Elisha and David. By addressing the young, often intimidated Timothy in this way, Paul reminds him that he does not belong to people's opinions or to the culture of Ephesus. He is God's own possession and stands in the noble line of prophets who held their ground alone against a faithless generation.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Here the Greek text unfolds a powerful symphony of charges, worship and stewardship:

- **The fourfold charge (vv. 11–12):** Paul fires four dynamic verbs at Timothy that sum up the rhythm of a faithful Christian life:
  - "*Flee*" (*pheuge* – φεῦγε): The present tense means to keep running away from the sins of greed, strife and false teaching. Spiritual courage knows when to run from temptation (see Joseph in Genesis 39:12).
  - "*Pursue*" (*diōke* – δίωκε): A hunting term meaning to stay tirelessly on the trail until you catch up with your quarry. While fleeing sin, you are to actively hunt down six Christlike qualities: righteousness, godliness, faith, love, endurance (*hypomonē* – staying on your feet under a heavy load) and gentleness (*praypathia*).

- "Fight" (*agōnizou* – ἀγωνίζου): In 1:18 Paul used a military image ("wage the good warfare"); here he chooses an athletic term from the Greek games (from which we get the word *agony*). It demands every ounce of strength and stamina in the arena of faith.
- "Take hold of" (*epilabou* – ἐπιλαβοῦ): To grasp eternal life with both hands – not to try to earn salvation, but to live practically and wholeheartedly out of the reality of the eternal life to which God has already called you and about which you made the good confession.

- **The good confession and the King of kings (vv. 13–16):** When Timothy is tempted to give in under pressure, Paul points him to Christ Jesus, who stood before the Roman governor Pontius Pilate. With his own life at stake, Jesus did not flinch but fearlessly testified to his kingship and to the truth (John 18:36–37). The thought of Christ's "appearing" (*epiphaneia*) makes Paul burst out once more into a majestic doxology. In contrast to the Roman emperors, worshipped in Ephesus as "lords" and "gods", Paul declares that God alone is the *Dynastēs* ("Sovereign"), that he "alone has immortality" (*athanasia*) and "dwells in unapproachable light" (*phōs aprositon*) – a blinding holiness and glory so pure that no sinful eye can look upon it.
- **The life that is truly life, for the rich (vv. 17–19):** Ephesus was an immensely wealthy commercial city, and there were well-to-do believers in the church. Notice Paul's balance: he does not order them to throw away their possessions and become poor; he even affirms that God richly provides us with everything "to enjoy" (*eis apolausin*). But he warns against the two great diseases of wealth: arrogance (*hypsēlophronein* – looking down on others because you are rich) and false security (setting your hope on the *adēlotēs* – the fickle uncertainty – of money). Instead of being rich in bank accounts, they are to be "rich in good works", "generous" (*eumetadotous*) and "ready to share" (*koinōnikous*). In this way they "take hold of the life that is truly life" (*tēs ontōs zōēs*).

- **"Guard what has been entrusted to you" (*tēn parathēkēn phylaxon* – τὴν παραθήκην φύλαξον, v. 20):** Paul closes the letter with an emotional cry: "O Timothy, *guard what has been entrusted to you*." In ancient law, a *parathēkē* was a precious treasure or deposit handed to a trusted person for safekeeping. The keeper had no right to alter it or claim it for himself; he had to protect it with his life and return it intact. This deposit is the pure gospel of Jesus Christ. Timothy is to turn his back on "what is falsely called knowledge" (*pseudōnymos gnōsis* – the early seeds of Gnosticism, which boasted of secret intellectual knowledge). Those who ran after this sham wisdom "swerved from the faith" (*ēstochēsan* – an archer's term meaning to miss the target completely).

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Holiness is a double movement.** No believer stays spiritually healthy by knowing only what he is against (*flee*), without living passionately for what he is called to (*pursue*).
2. **God's sovereign majesty is the anchor of our courage.** When we grasp that we serve the King of kings who dwells in unapproachable light, earthly "Pilates" and human threats lose their grip on our hearts.
3. **Generosity turns passing money into eternal treasure.** Earthly wealth is shifting sand when you build your hope on it, but it becomes a firm foundation for eternity when it is used to bless others.
4. **We are guardians, not designers, of the truth.** The gospel is a holy *parathēkē*, a treasure entrusted to us. Our highest calling is to carry the torch of faith unstained until our King appears.

Living It Out

At the end of our journey through 1 Timothy, Paul leaves us with a programme for life that directs every day of our walk with the Lord.

First, ask yourself: **What am I running away from – and what am I running towards?** Many Christians define their faith only negatively – by all the things they do *not* do. But if you only try to flee from sin without actively filling your heart with the pursuit of righteousness, love, endurance and gentleness, you will burn out spiritually. What are you sweating for in the arena today (*agōnizou*)?

Second, look at Paul's wise counsel about our possessions and finances (vv. 17–19). Compared with the rest of world history, most of us who have a regular income, a home and a car today belong to "the rich in this present age". God does not begrudge us the joy of his blessings – after all, he richly provides us with everything "to enjoy"! But the temptation is always to tie our peace of mind and our identity to our savings, our pensions and our assets. A single economic crash or a single medical diagnosis shows how quickly "the uncertainty of riches" can evaporate. How do you break the power of materialism over your soul? By giving deliberately, generously and willingly. Every time you open your hand to support God's work and people in need, you move your treasure from a temporary earthly bank to an imperishable heavenly account – and taste here and now what "the life that is truly life" feels like.

Finally, Paul's last appeal rings personally in each of our ears. **Put your own name into verse 20: "O [your name], guard what has been entrusted to you!"** For two thousand years believers before us – often at the cost of their own blood – have guarded the pure gospel of grace so that it could be in our hands today. Now it is our shift on the wall. Do not let the "falsely called knowledge" of our modern spirit of the age lead you away from the cross of Jesus Christ. Hold on to what has been entrusted to you until the King of kings appears!

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Am I as purposeful and passionate in *pursuing* righteousness, love, endurance and gentleness as I am in fleeing *from* worldly temptations?

- Where does my deepest financial security lie today: in the shifting security of my earthly assets, or in God – as I use my blessings with an open, generous hand to store up a good foundation for the future?
- At the end of this journey through 1 Timothy: which specific part of what has been entrusted to me – in my personal conscience, my household or my involvement in the local church – is the Lord calling me to guard with new seriousness from today on?

Prayer

Blessed and only Sovereign, King of kings and Lord of lords! You alone have immortality and dwell in unapproachable light – before you I bow today in deep worship and wonder.

I thank you from the bottom of my heart for the journey on which you have led me through this letter to Timothy. Thank you that your Word has searched my conscience, renewed my mind and fixed my eyes afresh on the glory of Jesus Christ, our only Mediator and Saviour.

Lord, give me the grace as a child of God to flee from everything that defiles my soul, and to pursue righteousness, godliness, faith, love, endurance and gentleness with unquenchable zeal. When the fight of faith grows fierce, remind me of Jesus, who made the good confession before Pilate, and make me steadfast and unafraid.

Free me from the delusion of setting my hope on earthly goods or uncertain riches. As I gratefully enjoy what you provide from your Father's hand, make me rich in good works, generous and ready to share, so that I take hold of the life that is truly life with both hands.

And now, Lord, help me by your Holy Spirit to guard the precious treasure of the gospel you have entrusted to me, spotless and above reproach, until the wonderful day when Jesus Christ appears in glory. To you be all honour and eternal dominion, for ever and ever. Amen.

The whole of First Timothy

The complete text of Paul's first letter to Timothy in the translation used in these devotionals.

Chapter 1

[1] Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the command of God our Saviour and of Christ Jesus our hope, [2] to Timothy, my true child in the faith: grace, mercy and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord.

[3] As I urged you when I was going on to Macedonia, stay on in Ephesus, so that you may instruct certain people not to teach a different doctrine [4] and not to occupy themselves with myths and endless genealogies, which produce speculations rather than God's ordering of things, which is by faith – [5] but the goal of our instruction is love from a pure heart, from a good conscience and from a sincere faith. [6] Some have strayed from these and have turned aside to empty talk. [7] They want to be teachers of the law, without understanding either what they are saying or the things about which they make such confident claims. [8] Now we know that the law is good, if one uses it lawfully, [9] knowing this: the law is not laid down for the righteous, but for the lawless and rebellious, for the ungodly and sinners, for the unholy and profane, for those who kill their fathers or their mothers, for murderers, [10] for the sexually immoral, for men who have sex with men, for slave traders, for liars, for perjurers, and for whatever else is contrary to sound teaching, [11] in keeping with the gospel of the glory of the blessed God, which was entrusted to me.

[12] I give thanks to him who has strengthened me, Christ Jesus our Lord, because he judged me faithful and appointed me to his service, [13] though I was formerly a blasphemer, a persecutor and a violent man. But I was shown mercy, because I acted in ignorance and unbelief. [14] And the grace of our Lord overflowed, together with the faith and love that are in Christ Jesus. [15] This is a trustworthy saying and deserves full acceptance: Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners – and of them I am the first. [16] But for this very reason I

was shown mercy: so that in me, as the first, Christ Jesus might display his complete patience, as an example for those who were going to believe in him for eternal life.

17 Now to the King of the ages,
the imperishable, invisible, only God,
be honour and glory for ever and ever. Amen.

18 This instruction I entrust to you, Timothy, my child, in keeping with the prophecies once made about you, so that by them you may wage the good warfare, 19 holding on to faith and a good conscience. Some have pushed this conscience aside and have made shipwreck of their faith. 20 Among them are Hymenaeus and Alexander, whom I have handed over to Satan, so that they may be taught not to blaspheme.

Chapter 2

1 First of all, then, I urge that petitions, prayers, intercessions and thanksgivings be made for all people, 2 for kings and all who are in high positions, so that we may lead a peaceful and quiet life in all godliness and dignity. 3 This is good and pleasing before God our Saviour, 4 who wants all people to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth.

5 For there is one God,
and there is one mediator between God and humankind,
the man Christ Jesus,
6 who gave himself as a ransom for all –
the testimony at the proper time.

7 For this I was appointed a herald and an apostle – I am telling the truth, I am not lying – a teacher of the nations in faith and truth.

8 I want the men, then, to pray in every place, lifting up holy hands without anger or quarrelling. 9 Likewise also the women should adorn themselves in respectable clothing, with modesty and self-control, not with braided hair and gold or pearls or expensive clothing, 10 but – as is fitting for women who profess reverence for God – with good works. 11 A woman should learn in quietness, in all submission. 12 I do not permit a woman to teach, nor to exercise authority over a man; she is to be in quietness. 13 For Adam was formed

first, then Eve. [14] And Adam was not deceived, but the woman was deceived and fell into transgression. [15] But she will be saved through childbearing, if they remain in faith and love and holiness, with self-control.

Chapter 3

[1] This is a trustworthy saying: if anyone aspires to the office of overseer, he desires a good work. [2] The overseer, then, must be above reproach, the husband of one wife, sober-minded, self-controlled, respectable, hospitable, able to teach, [3] not a drunkard, not violent but gentle, not quarrelsome, not a lover of money, [4] one who manages his own household well and keeps his children in submission, with all dignity – [5] for if someone does not know how to manage his own household, how will he take care of God's church? – [6] not a recent convert, so that he does not become conceited and fall into the condemnation of the devil. [7] He must also have a good reputation with outsiders, so that he does not fall into disgrace and into the devil's trap. [8] Deacons likewise must be dignified, not double-tongued, not given to much wine, not greedy for dishonest gain, [9] holding the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience. [10] And let them also be tested first; then let them serve, if they prove blameless. [11] Women likewise must be dignified, not slanderers, sober-minded, faithful in all things. [12] Deacons must each be the husband of one wife, managing their children and their own households well. [13] For those who have served well gain a good standing for themselves and great confidence in the faith that is in Christ Jesus.

[14] I am writing these things to you, though I hope to come to you soon, [15] so that, if I am delayed, you may know how one ought to behave in the household of God, which is the church of the living God, a pillar and foundation of the truth. [16] And beyond all question, great is the mystery of godliness:

He was revealed in the flesh,
vindicated by the Spirit,
seen by angels,
proclaimed among the nations,
believed in throughout the world,
taken up in glory.

Chapter 4

[1] Now the Spirit says explicitly that in later times some will fall away from the faith, devoting themselves to deceiving spirits and teachings of demons,
[2] through the hypocrisy of liars whose own consciences have been branded.
[3] They forbid marriage and demand abstinence from foods that God created to be received with thanksgiving by those who believe and know the truth.
[4] For everything created by God is good, and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving, [5] for it is made holy by the word of God and prayer.

[6] If you put these things before the brothers and sisters, you will be a good servant of Christ Jesus, nourished on the words of the faith and of the good teaching that you have followed. [7] But have nothing to do with irreverent, old wives' myths. Rather, train yourself for godliness. [8] For bodily training is of little value, but godliness is of value in every way, holding promise for the present life and for the life to come. [9] This is a trustworthy saying and deserves full acceptance. [10] For to this end we toil and are reviled, because we have set our hope on the living God, who is the Saviour of all people, especially of those who believe.

[11] Instruct people in these things and teach them. [12] Let no one look down on you because of your youth, but set the believers an example in speech, in conduct, in love, in faith, in purity. [13] Until I come, devote yourself to the public reading of Scripture, to exhortation and to teaching. [14] Do not neglect the gift that is in you, which was given to you through prophecy when the council of elders laid their hands on you. [15] Put these things into practice, give yourself wholly to them, so that your progress may be evident to all. [16] Keep a close watch on yourself and on your teaching; persist in them. For by doing this you will save both yourself and those who hear you.

Chapter 5

[1] Do not rebuke an older man harshly, but encourage him as you would a father, younger men as brothers, [2] older women as mothers, younger women as sisters, in all purity.

[3] Honour widows who are truly widows. [4] But if a widow has children or grandchildren, let them first learn to show godliness towards their own household and to repay their parents, for this is pleasing before God. [5] The one who is truly a widow and left all alone has set her hope on God and continues in petitions and prayers night and day. [6] But the one who lives for pleasure is dead while she lives. [7] Instruct them in these things too, so that they may be above reproach. [8] But if anyone does not provide for his own relatives, and especially for members of his household, he has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever. [9] Let a widow be put on the list if she is not less than sixty years old, the wife of one husband, [10] and well known for good works: if she has brought up children, if she has shown hospitality, if she has washed the feet of the saints, if she has helped the afflicted, if she has devoted herself to every good work. [11] But refuse younger widows; for when their desires draw them away from Christ, they want to marry, [12] and so incur condemnation for having set aside their first faithfulness. [13] Besides that, they learn to be idle, going round from house to house; and not only idle, but also gossips and busybodies, saying what they should not. [14] So I want younger widows to marry, to have children, to manage their households, and to give the adversary no occasion for slander. [15] For some have already turned aside to follow Satan. [16] If any believing woman has widows in her family, let her help them, and let the church not be burdened, so that it may help those who are truly widows.

[17] Let the elders who lead well be considered worthy of double honour, especially those who labour in preaching and teaching. [18] For the Scripture says, "You shall not muzzle an ox while it is treading out the grain," and, "The worker deserves his wages." [19] Do not accept an accusation against an elder except on the evidence of two or three witnesses. [20] Those who persist in sin, rebuke in the presence of all, so that the rest may also stand in fear. [21] I solemnly charge you before God and Christ Jesus and the chosen angels to keep these rules without prejudice, doing nothing out of favouritism. [22] Do not be hasty in the laying on of hands, and do not take part in the sins of others. Keep yourself pure. [23] No longer drink only water, but use a little wine for the sake of your stomach and your frequent illnesses. [24] The sins of some peo-

ple are obvious, going ahead of them to judgement, but the sins of others follow after them. 25 So also good works are obvious, and even those that are not cannot remain hidden.

Chapter 6

1 Let all who are under the yoke as slaves regard their own masters as worthy of all honour, so that the name of God and the teaching may not be blasphemed. 2 Those who have believing masters must not look down on them because they are brothers; rather, they must serve them all the better, because those who benefit from their good service are believers and beloved. Teach and urge these things.

3 If anyone teaches a different doctrine and does not agree with the sound words of our Lord Jesus Christ and with the teaching that accords with godliness, 4 he is puffed up and understands nothing. He has an unhealthy craving for controversies and quarrels about words, which produce envy, strife, slander, evil suspicions, 5 and constant friction among people who are corrupted in mind and deprived of the truth, who think that godliness is a means of gain. 6 But godliness with contentment is great gain. 7 For we brought nothing into the world, and we cannot take anything out of it. 8 But if we have food and clothing, with these we will be content. 9 But those who want to be rich fall into temptation, into a trap, and into many senseless and harmful desires that plunge people into ruin and destruction. 10 For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil. Some, by craving it, have wandered away from the faith and pierced themselves with many pains.

11 But you, man of God, flee from these things. Pursue righteousness, godliness, faith, love, endurance, gentleness. 12 Fight the good fight of the faith. Take hold of the eternal life to which you were called and about which you made the good confession in the presence of many witnesses. 13 I charge you before God, who gives life to all things, and before Christ Jesus, who in his testimony before Pontius Pilate made the good confession, 14 to keep the commandment spotless and above reproach until the appearing of our Lord Jesus Christ,

15 which he will display at the proper time –
he who is the blessed and only Sovereign,

the King of kings and Lord of lords,
16 who alone has immortality,
who dwells in unapproachable light,
whom no one has ever seen or can see.
To him be honour and eternal dominion. Amen.

17 As for the rich in this present age, instruct them not to be arrogant, nor to
set their hope on the uncertainty of riches, but on God, who richly provides
us with everything to enjoy. 18 They are to do good, to be rich in good works,
to be generous and ready to share, 19 so storing up for themselves a good foun-
dation for the future, so that they may take hold of the life that is truly life.

20 O Timothy, guard what has been entrusted to you. Turn away from irrever-
ent, empty chatter and the contradictions of what is falsely called knowledge,
21 which some have professed and so have swerved from the faith. Grace be
with you all.